



FOR THE VIDEO GAME HISTORY FOUNDATION

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# USER SURVEY REPORT

VGHF GAMES PRESERVATION SURVEY ANALYSIS



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# SURVEY REPORT DETAILS

## OVERVIEW & REPORT FLOW

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The 2026 VGHF User Survey was an extremely successful debut, having received 144 responses, 135 of which were used to synthesize the results presented in this report. The findings from this analysis surfaces insightful and actionable data for developing our collection development policy, and I believe it will continue to be helpful for further development of the VGHF's digital library. This analysis steps through the survey questions in the order they were presented to respondents due to the evolving flow designed into the survey. Opening questions about the user's perspective lead to easy questions about the user's relationship with the VGHF, before delving into more complex questions about how the user interacts with and feels about using the VGHF's digital library. Then it concludes by exploring specifics about the user's relationship with archival preservation within their relative role(s) around games and archivalship. Finally, it ends with Bubsy vs. Gex, but don't cheat yourself of the satisfaction of how important that question will end up being for the survey, we'll get there.

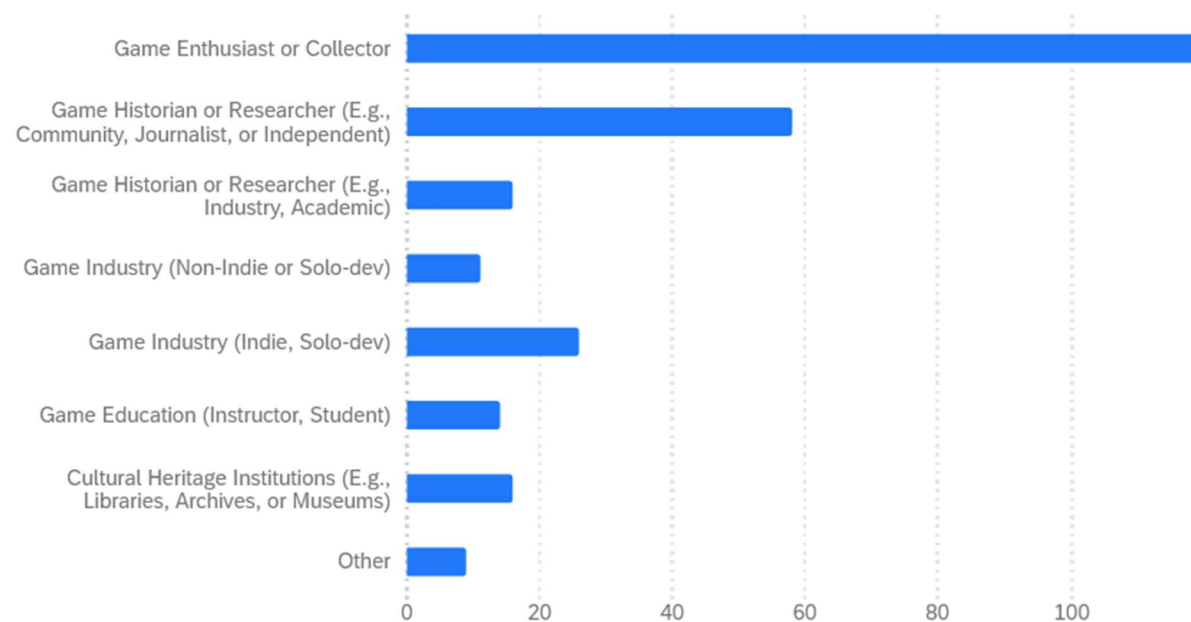
## METHOD

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This survey was developed for the Qualtrics survey platform, which also hosted the survey and tabulated the data, and then afterwards Qualtrics was used for data analysis and many of the graphs used in this report. 90% of respondents finished the survey with 80% of respondents taking <8 minutes to complete it. Our method of capturing the userbase with a banner on the digital library's main page for three weeks from May 7th to June 3rd captured about 50 users, and a call-to-action to the VGHF email listserv inside an update email in the middle of the campaign captured the other 90 (rough estimate based on the bump after the email since we can't know for sure if any users read the email who would have taken the survey on their own). Based on the responses, I would say this worked well to find a diverse mix of users and so lets prove that with the first question:

# SECTION ONE – HOW DO USERS RELATE TO US?

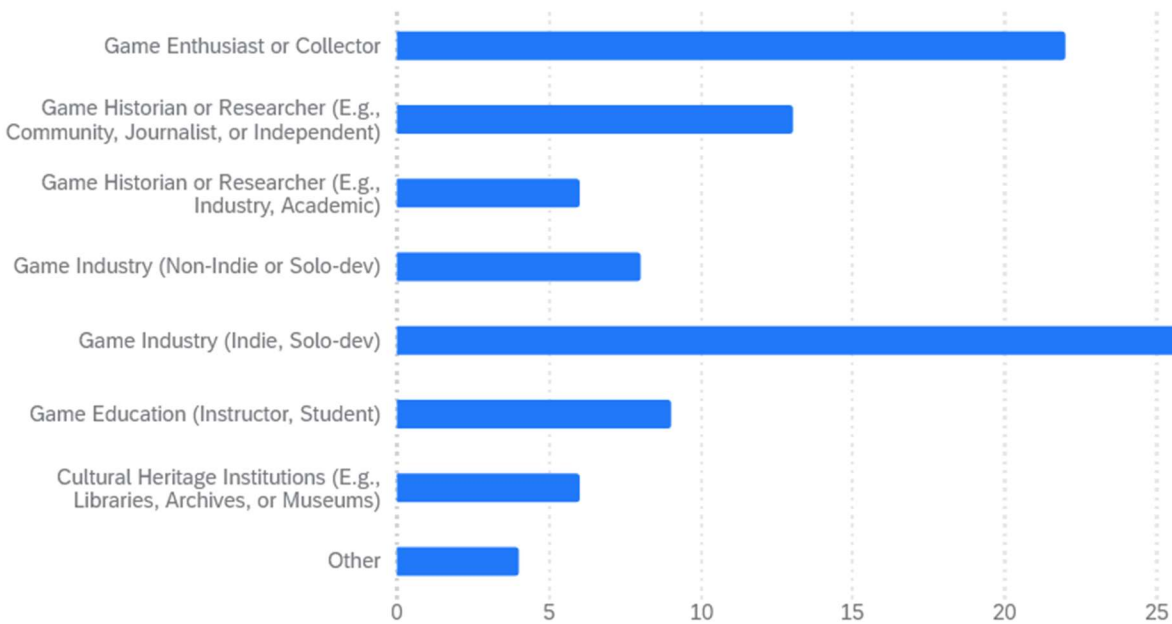
## Q1: PRESERVATION PERSPECTIVES – IDENTITY ROLES



*Q: Which of the following digital game preservation formats do you most associate with the VGHF?*

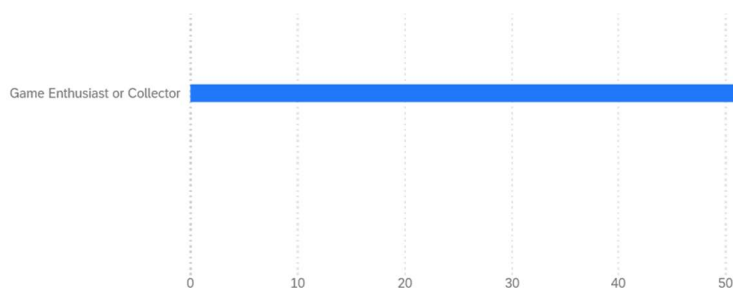
Our opening question is the only one that every respondent must answer, all others are optional even when they aren't listed as such. Users selected roles they identify with and could attribute any or all of them to their survey. They were then asked a series of role-specific questions at the end of their survey, so if they were one of the four users who selected every option, they were given six extra sets of questions compared to the fifty users who only selected [Game Enthusiast or Collector]. This simple approach aligned with capturing a comprehensive landscape of the user identities that utilize the Digital Library. An alternative approach for next time could be identifying a user's *primary* identity, for stronger associative relationships in the data. In future work, when identifying roles to include as anticipated respondent identities additional consideration may be warranted for teasing out the following relationships:

- 50% of Independent Game Developer (Indie Devs) that also identified as Independent Historian/Researcher (Indie Historians)
- 69% of Cultural Heritage Institutions (LAMs) that also identified as Indie Devs
- 100% of Non-Indie Game Industry (Pro Devs) that also identified as Indie Devs



*Q: Which of the following games preservation perspectives do you identify with? (Selected Indie Devs)*

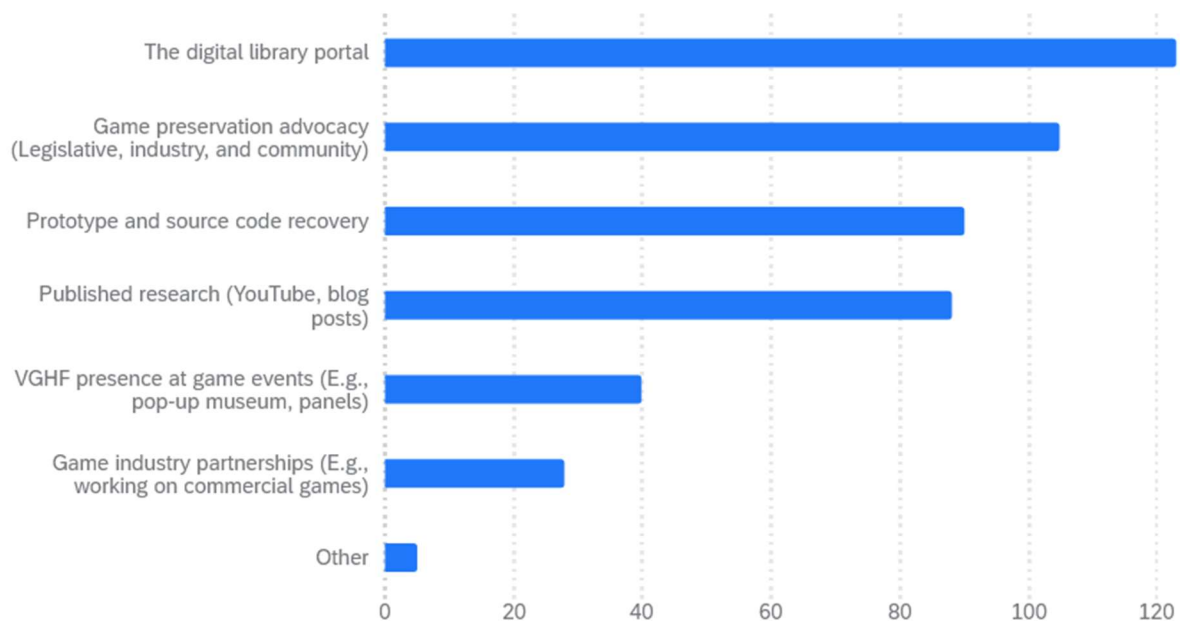
For this report we will use the following terminology to break down the rest of the data from this survey: Indie Historians, Pro Historians, Indie Devs, Pro Devs, LAMs, Educators, and Enthusiasts (NOTE: these labels are reductive for brevity sake - Educators, as a classification, will also possibly refer to students or related education faculty using the digital library for research). The exception to how these classifications work is [Enthusiasts] who are always referred to as an exclusive class. As almost everyone who took the survey declared they were an enthusiast or game collector, it becomes very fruitful to identify the group of 51 who ONLY identified as that role as seen in the diagram below.



*Q: Which of the following digital game preservation formats do you most associate with the VGHF? (Only Selected [Game Enthusiast or Collector] Exclusively)*

## Q2: WHICH VGHF PROJECTS EXCITE USERS?

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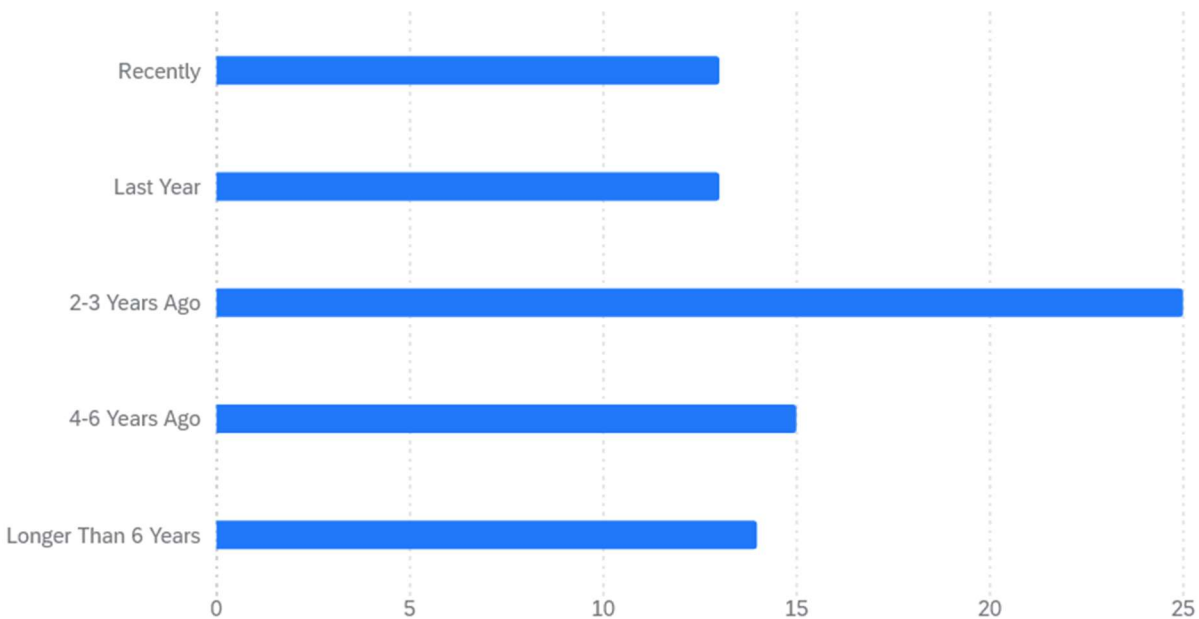


*Q: What types of VGHF projects are you most interested in?*

These results establish that the digital library portal is the foremost project that users are interested in, and while that is expected, it is also maintained as the most important across all of the identity groups. [Advocacy] is the second most interesting project the VGHF is involved in, except to Pro Historians and Pro Devs who were slightly more interested in [Published research]. LAMs are the most interested in live presence at game events (53% of LAM respondents) and so are Pro Historians (44% of respondents). The other outlier, as one could expect, is that Pro Devs are the group most heavily interested in the game industry partnerships (55%). An unexpected takeaway from this is how popular [Prototype and source code recovery] is to users. This will be a theme throughout the report: despite being not nearly as directly impactful to digital library users as many of the other options (currently video games are not even operationalizable for researchers in their current form), just the possibility of playing a rare game is of great interest to 67% of all users with every group being about that high. The last important point about this question's data is that even the lowest ranked options are of interest to over 1/5 of all users, without even mentioning the names of games that have previously been impacted by [Game industry partnerships]. This is a high amount of interest in many aspects of an archive's services, which flags a healthy optimism from archive users.

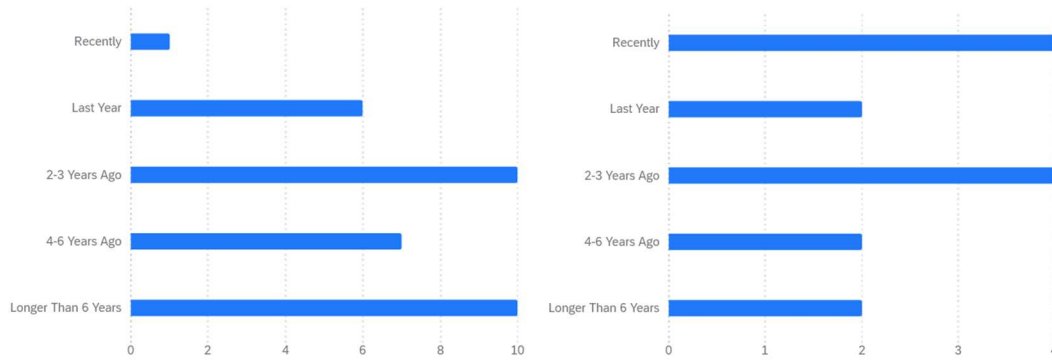
### Q3: WHEN DO USERS FIND THE VGHF?

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*Q: About how long ago did you hear about the VGHF?*

Unlike other questions, this one was choice-exclusive and only 59% of respondents answered, as I assume not everyone will be able to date their relationship to their favorite archive of paper Marios. Alternatively, it's amazing that 59% of VGHF digital library users CAN do that. Hooray for nerds! [2-3 Years Ago] was specifically when the 87% research release was published, so this is solid proof of to what extent that research impacted how users understand and identify the ways the VGHF is an organization that is working for them. But there are interesting details obscured by how even these bars seem. No individual group's breakdown mirrors this chart, but 75% of LAMs-identifying users, 50% of Indie Historians, and 38% of Pro Historians have known about the VGHF for more than 3 years. By contrast, Educators (3/7), Indie Devs (6/14), Pro Devs (3/7), and Enthusiasts (12/30) make up a majority of all of the most recent users coming in to use the digital library resources. As someone who was in the room at GDC 2023 when Frank Cifaldi presented the "87%" research (and then six months later applied to my nearest library school), I can only assume looking at this data that this is all part of some twisted plan to turn game developers into archivists and museum curators. Or maybe the only true difference between a developer and a historian is time...



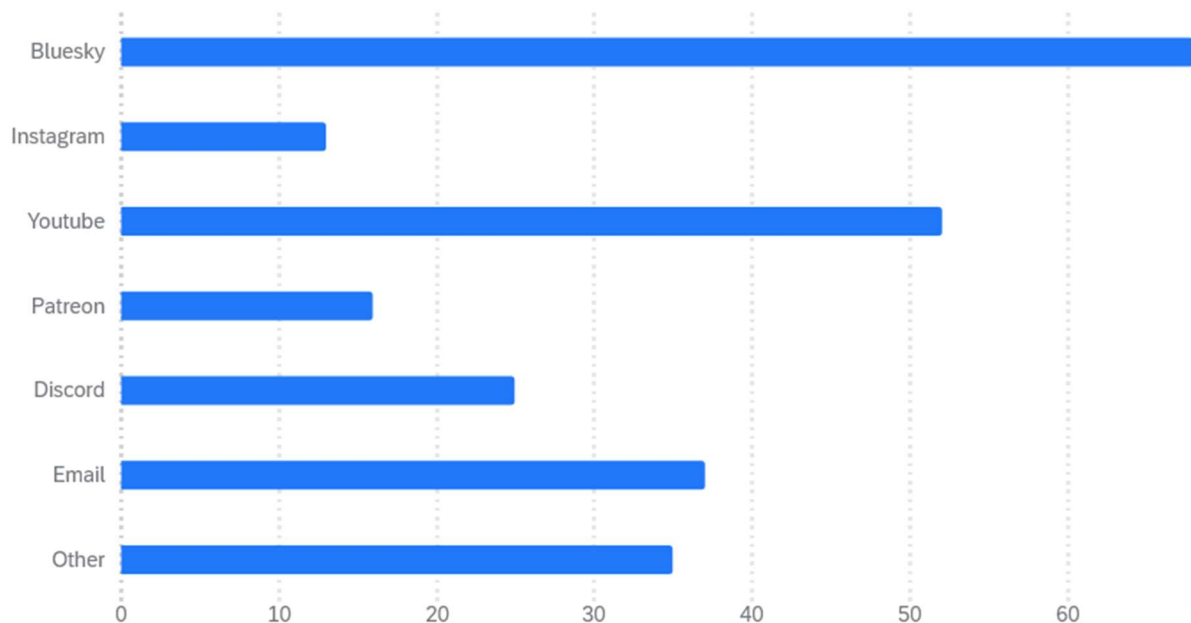
Q: About how long ago did you hear about the VGHF

[LEFT-Indie Historians] [RIGHT-Indie Devs]

(LEFT-34 Responses) (RIGHT-14 Responses)

More specifically, we can see from these graphs the impact that the launch of the digital library last year has had on growing the library’s userbase. Developers and scholars are recognizing the digital library as an important tool for accessing games history, leading to a sustainable influx of new users.

#### Q4: WHERE ARE USERS INFORMED ABOUT THE VGHF?



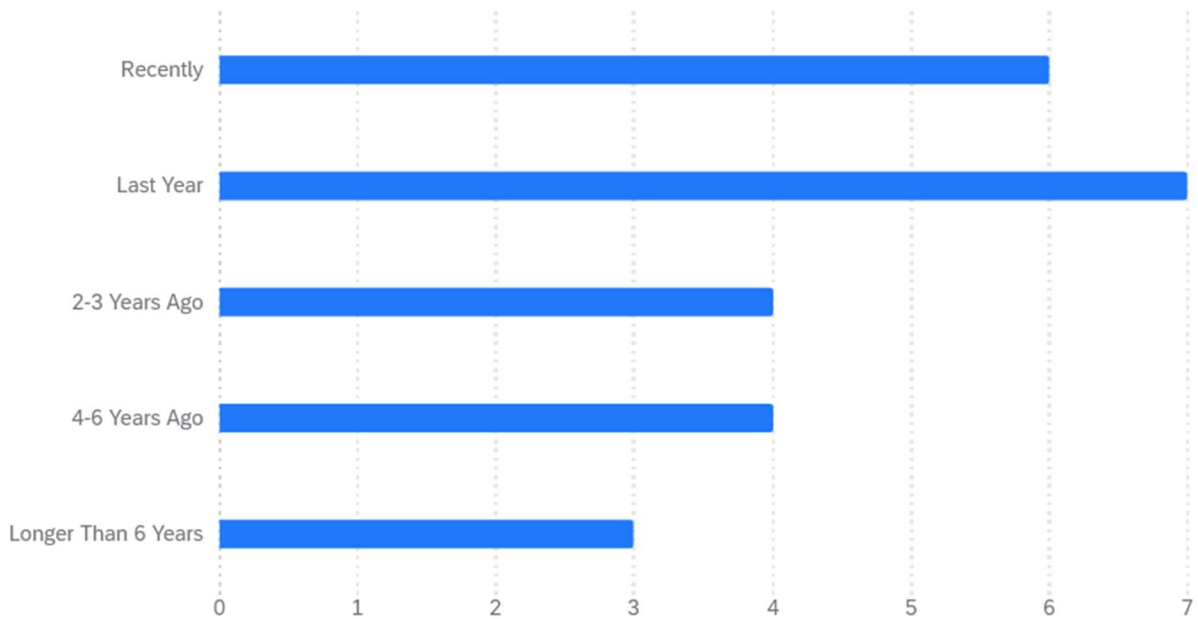
Q: Where do you obtain information regarding the activities of the VGHF?



This question asks users where they get information, but only lists places where the VGHF currently has a presence, which limits the ways users can respond. It also pushes more users to select [Other]. This was important as it is the only question whose options were changed while the survey was running. Originally we did not have a [Youtube] option but the [Other] group made it clear within the first week that it was missing from the list. After reassociating those who chose Other and wrote in Youtube, the results of this question become a pretty strong reflection of where the VGHF has been the most active publicly within the last three years. VGHF's reach on Bluesky and Youtube has seen strong growth over this time whereas Patreon, Discord, and Email, as more exclusive on-ramps for a richer relationship with the VGHF's activity, are overwhelmingly used by users who found the VGHF over 2+ years ago (84%). These relationships become more distinct when you break it down by user roles as there are stronger demarcations between audiences.

- Indie Historians and Pro Devs prefer Bluesky (66% and 50%)
- LAM users prefer Email (50%)
- Educators prefer Other (53%, mostly listing the VGHF website itself as the source, the GDC Vault, and Google)
  - Educators do not prefer Bluesky (23%) or Youtube (15%)
- Pro Historians use all of them (~33% use any or many of the options)
- Indie Devs prefer Bluesky and Youtube (48% and 40%)

All of these statistics suggest a soft divide between users with professional ties who prefer more direct methods of information like Email or the VGHF's website, whereas users with more personal ties to their work rely on social media platforms like Bluesky and Youtube to serve them VGHF information. Overall, this ends up naturally matching the VGHF's pursuits, where the goal of utilizing diverse formats for information dissemination is to reach diverse audiences where they are comfortable. But that's not all these details reveal if we return to our question about how long ago :

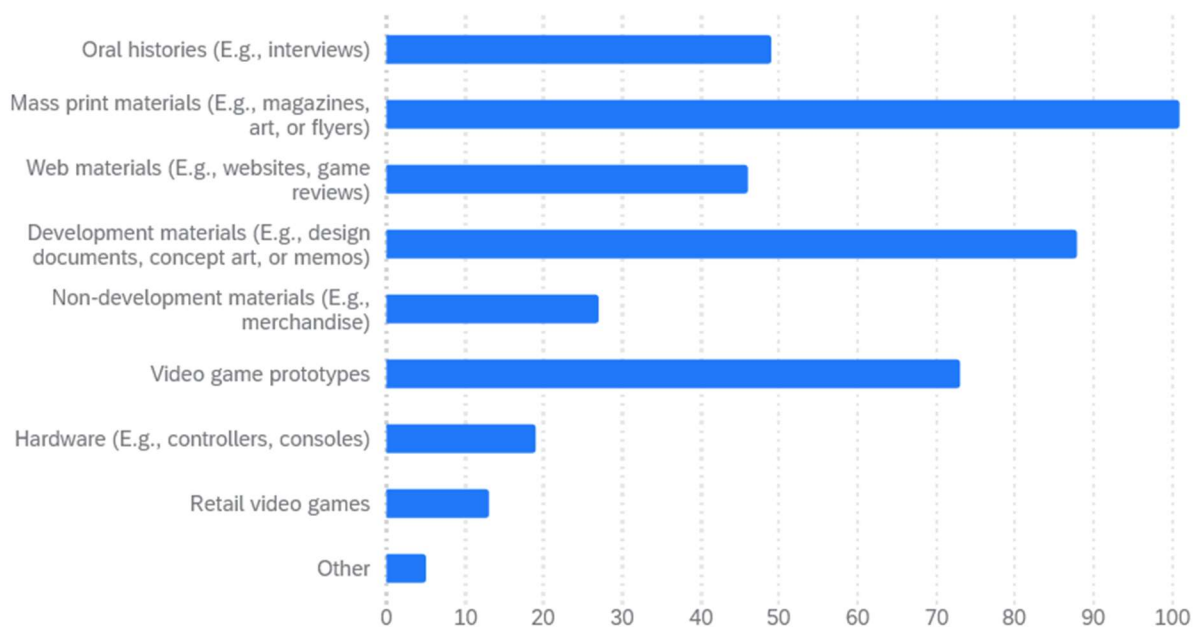


*Q: About how long ago did you hear about the VGHF?  
(Users that responded [Other] to “Where Do You Obtain Info...”)*

Now that we are four questions in, we can start analyzing data by anchoring other questions. Relating this question's data to the previous question I wanted to know: where do most recent users come from? Or more specifically: where do the more recent users (i.e., learned of the VGHF within the last year) get their VGHF information? Well, it wasn't easy finding a clear trend or association; the only weighted option that shows a majority of users who selected [Recently] or [Last Year] get their VGHF news from [Other] (mostly direct search or various places around the web), which makes me think that there is a consistent contingent of 'walk-ins' who show up without any ties to VGHF's social media presence and are more generally interested in using the digital library. The majority of all other users who get information directly from a place where the VGHF has a presence have known about the VGHF for over 2 years.

## Q5: WHAT DO USERS BELIEVE THE VGHF DOES?

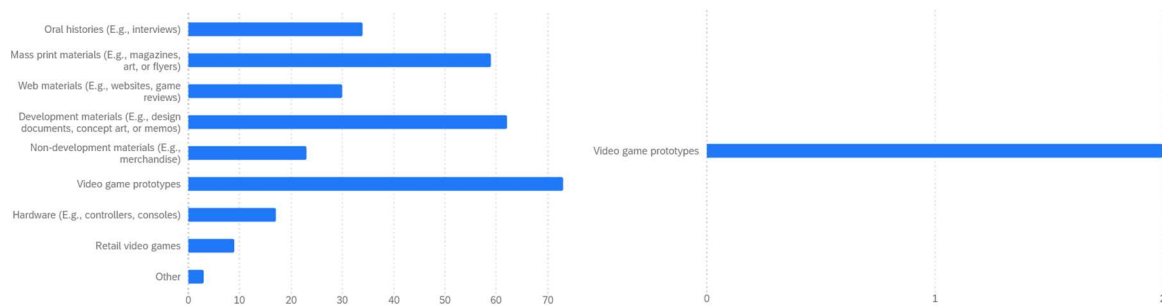
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*Q: Which of the following digital game preservation formats do you most associate with the VGHF?*

Question 5 is a much more thorough test of how the users understand what materials the VGHF works with than Question 2 was. Survey-takers were explicitly told that some options listed are not in the VGHF's collection, and they were asked for their strongest association but not limited in how many options they could choose. It wasn't designed to be subtle as the top four are digital formats that could be in the digital library and the bottom four are physical formats that wouldn't be in the digital library, but the power of seeing the VGHF working with prototype chips is a very strong image in people's minds. 76% of respondents identified that magazines are the format they most associate with the VGHF, and only 35% of respondents identified [Web materials] as something they believed the VGHF hosts when that is not something currently in the domain of the collection. As the designer of the question, I would currently associate [Mass print materials], [Oral histories], and [Dev materials] as primary parts of the VGHF's collection and all the other choices as not part of the VGHF's collection. But if I didn't know well-enough that prototypes could be problematic to host on a digital server, I'd probably have added that too just because seeing librarians holding green computer chips has been an iconic image in the VGHF's video and livestream output. So, I'm not surprised that 55% of respondents bit on [Video game prototypes]. And it's not for misunderstanding the question, as almost everyone who answered this selected multiple formats. Focusing this data on only the respondents who answered with Prototypes shows that their answers only skew a little from everyone else by focusing more on dev materials (the most similar material on the list to game prototypes, as a similarly direct output of video game production). But if we focus on users who exclusively answered Prototypes, there are only two – which is normal compared to other exclusive answers except Magazines, which 14

users committed to being the sole format they *Most* associate with the VGHF. Just because it is high, does not mean users are confident with the choice, just that they loosely overlap.



*Q: Which of the following digital game preservation formats do you most associate with the VGHF?*

*(LEFT- Users Who Chose Prototypes)*

*(RIGHT- Users Who Chose Prototypes Exclusively)*

*[LEFT- 73 Responses]*

*[RIGHT- 2 Responses]*

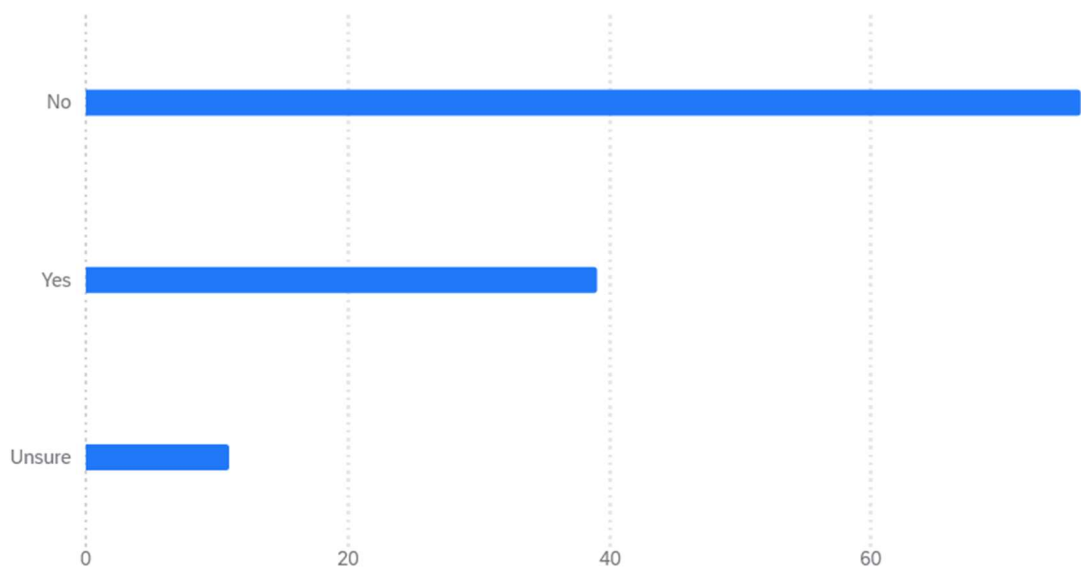
So who is responsible for pushing the prototype agenda? The pure [Enthusiasts] crowd (who, again, are the only group represented as exclusive and have no overlap with other roles) by far selected it most often with 62% of all Enthusiast/Collectors pressing their thumb on the scale, followed behind by Indie Historians (55%) and Indie Devs (50%). This could be a preservation fandom influence if Enthusiasts are the most keyed-in to what the VGHF is doing, but the volume of response to Question 3 doesn't indicate that. This also could be Collectors being specifically hungry for prototypes as it is something they would have direct stake in. But due to how the Dev groups also have a stake but didn't bite as hard, I believe this can only be explained by a lack of expertise that would also align with the other two hobbyist roles, Indie Historians and Indie Devs. It is my recommendation as a pro-wrestling fan and a librarian to use this data with respect and care because the data is calling our dear Enthusiasts big-time money marks who will jump at any perceived 'prototype' in a way that could come into conflict with inflated collectors markets taking advantage of a preservation-based grey market. I do not believe that the content of 80s prototypes carry the same historical value that enthusiasts would believe they do, but I also can't blame 'em for wanting to believe in these small green chips with cryptic secrets inside from days of yore. They are basically runestones. Catnip for geeks. It's not the main thing most people associate with the VGHF's work, but it is a major component that people associate with Value and there are groups that want the VGHF to carry that value.



## SECTION TWO – MONEY TALKS

### Q6: WHICH USERS DONATE TO THE VGHF?

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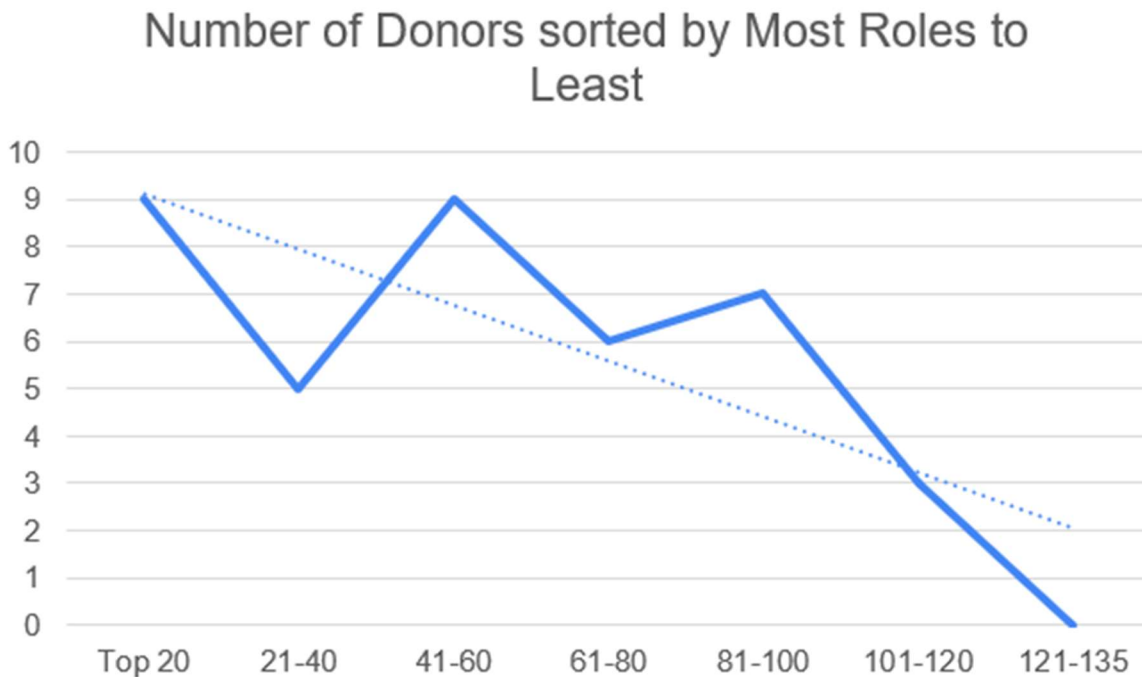
*Q: Have you ever donated to the VGHF before? (E.g., Patreon, direct donation, Humble Bundle, fundraisers)*

Question 6 is a simple exclusive choice yes-no question with an [Unsure] option for survey takers that, for our purposes, we will default as to meaning [No]. 29% of all respondents have donated to the VGHF in some capacity. All specific roles but two were majority donors.

| Identity Group   | Percent who identify as Donors |
|------------------|--------------------------------|
| Pro Devs         | 75% (6)                        |
| LAMs             | 57% (8)                        |
| Educators        | 63% (7)                        |
| Pro Historians   | 50% (6)                        |
| Indie Historians | 40% (22)                       |
| Indie Devs       | 30% (7)                        |

|                          |          |
|--------------------------|----------|
| Enthusiasts <sup>1</sup> | 20% (10) |
|--------------------------|----------|

Some of this data is of too low quantity to make strong associations about how someone's role might impact donations. But we can make an association between how many roles someone has:



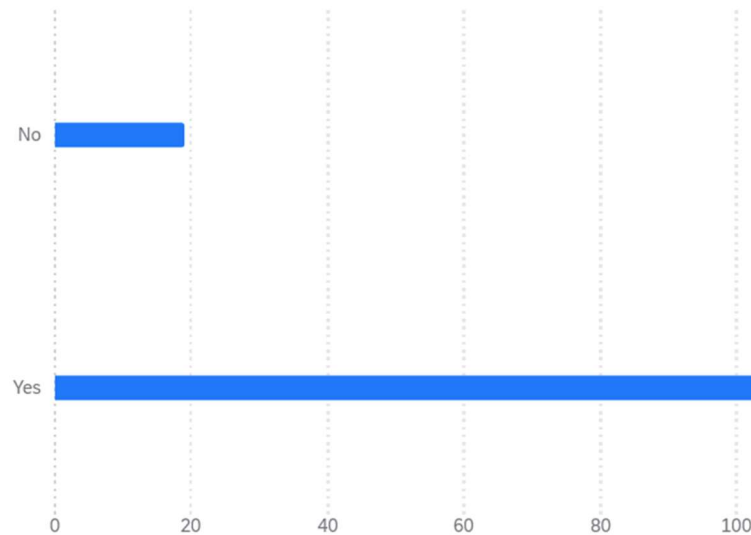
If you sort all of the respondents in order from most roles to fewest (The top 33 chose three or more roles, and the bottom 62 all chose a single role, mostly Enthusiasts), this chart shows that those who are involved in many ways with games could be two or even three times as likely to be donors than those who are singularly involved. This isn't entirely surprising as those are likely respondents who not only would have more motivating factors but also more access to donatable materials.

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<sup>1</sup> The Enthusiasts value can't be compared directly to the others in this chart as theirs is an exclusive group. So, for example, there were two users who identified as donors and a part of every identity group but they did not get added to this Enthusiasts exclusive group like they did to every other identity group in the table.

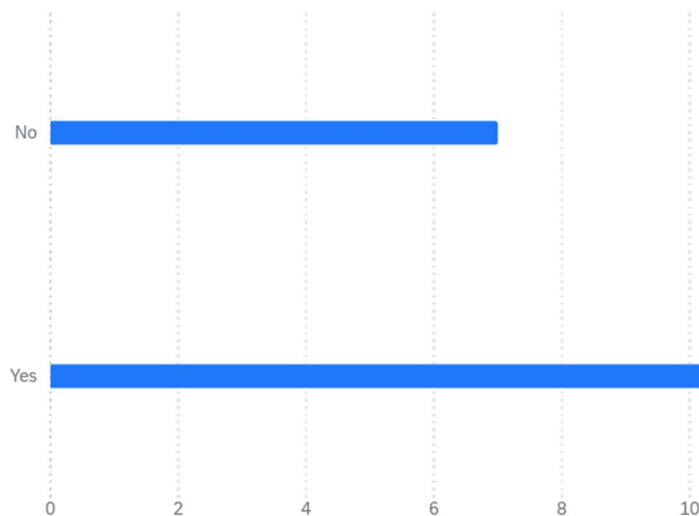
## Q7 & Q8: DIGITAL LIBRARY USAGE

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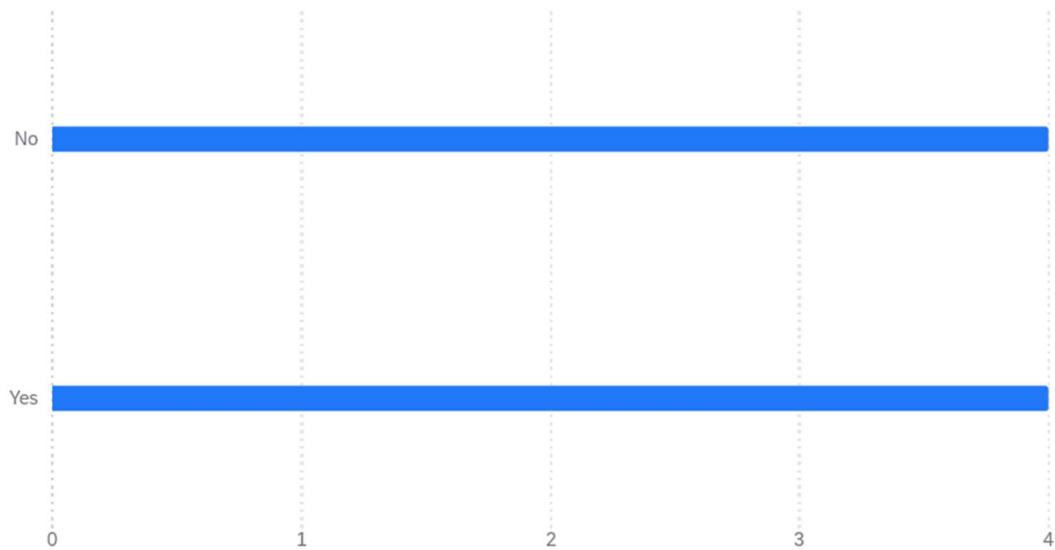
*Q: Have you ever utilized the VGHF digital library?*

I wanted there to be a short, simple pair of questions to invite folks into the survey and reiterate what the focus of the survey is before we get into Digital Library-specific questions. These are especially helpful for identifying if anyone found the survey in any way without having actually used the digital library so that I can filter their survey in a way that doesn't throw complex questions at respondents that they can't answer. The 18 users who answered [No] were given an extra question:



*Q: Did you know before today that the VGHF provides a free digital library anyone can use to examine rare historical and consumer documents from our library's collection?*

It's not just a fun and polite novelty that seven respondents got to learn about the VGHF's missions statement for the Digital Library through our survey – we now know there are users who regularly find the website through organic means and that over half of potential users who haven't used the digital library yet are at least aware that it exists. There is one outlier group among our user-defined roles too. While almost all roles were overwhelmingly digital library users, the Pro Devs group were split 50/50 as folks who have and have not used it.

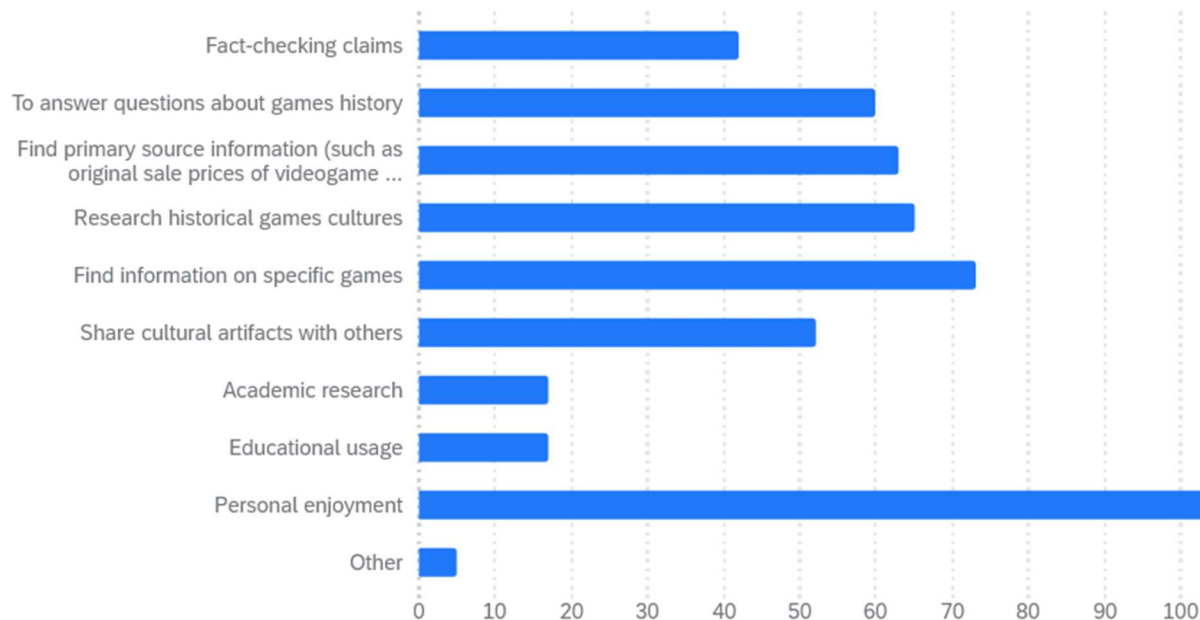


*Q: Have you ever utilized the VGHF digital library? (Pro Devs only)*

## SECTION THREE: USER MOTIVATIONS

### Q9: HOW DO WE HELP USERS EXPRESS THEIR EXPERTISE?

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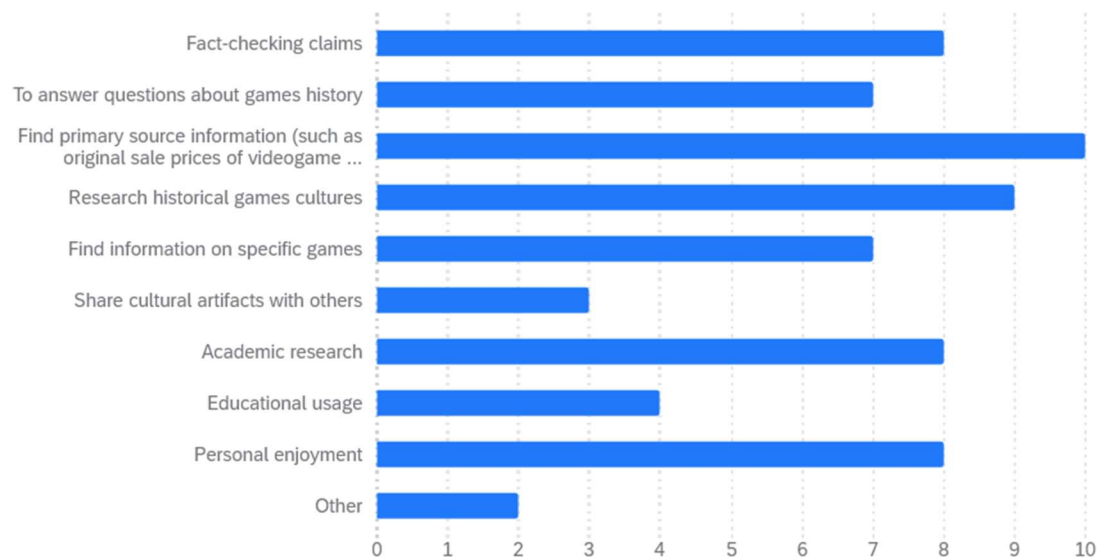
*Q: How do the materials hosted by the VGHF digital library benefit you and/or your work?*

This is the final question that was given to every survey respondent regardless of how previous questions were answered, and it is probably the most important of the entire survey. We are directly asking all users what ways they use the Digital Library's resources and so in turn they are providing us with insights on how much they are supported by the library's resources. Overall, respondents spread widely across all the answers and almost everyone ubiquitously responded that they used the library for [Personal Enjoyment]. 19 users selected that as their only option and 20 users did not select [Personal Enjoyment] at all (this subset is overwhelmingly interested in [Researching Historical Game Cultures] (65%), [Finding Primary Source Information] (60%), and [Finding Information on Specific Games] (55%)).

Because this is such an important question and every role gave distinctly different answers, I am going to display all seven group graphs of the data:



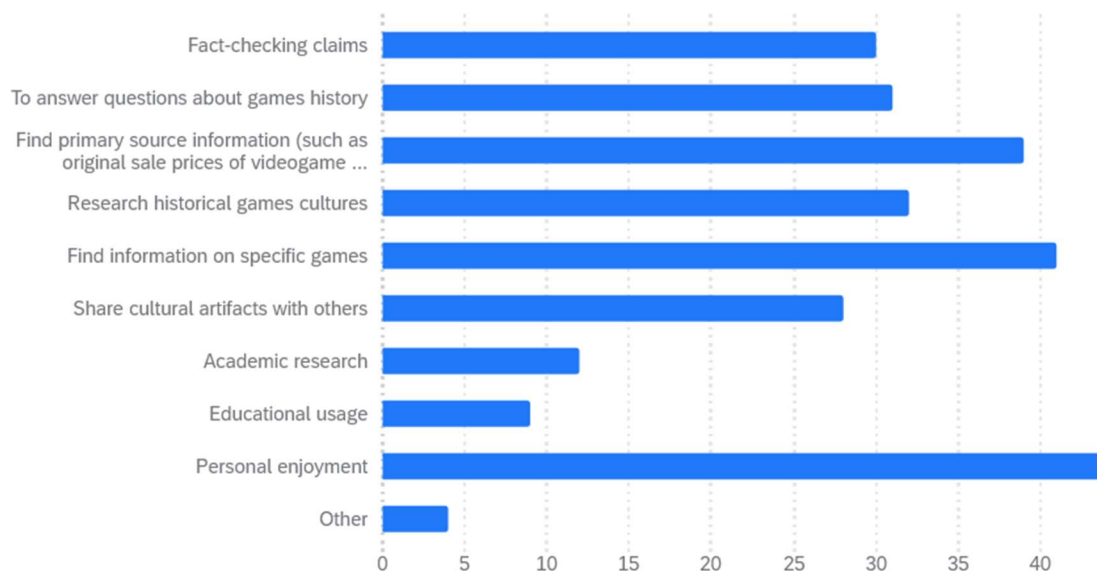
### PRO HISTORIANS - [12 RESPONSES]



*Q: How do the materials hosted by the VGHF Digital Library benefit you and/or your work?  
(Pro Historians)*

Our faculty historian group is high on primary source information, games culture, fact-checking, and academic research. They are the only group that is busy enough with work right now that [Personal enjoyment] isn't a priority. They also have little use for sharing with others, which I assume is due to their research's more direct applications. Overall, our Pro Historian users seem to be successfully finding many ways to apply the digital library's resources towards historical stewardship.

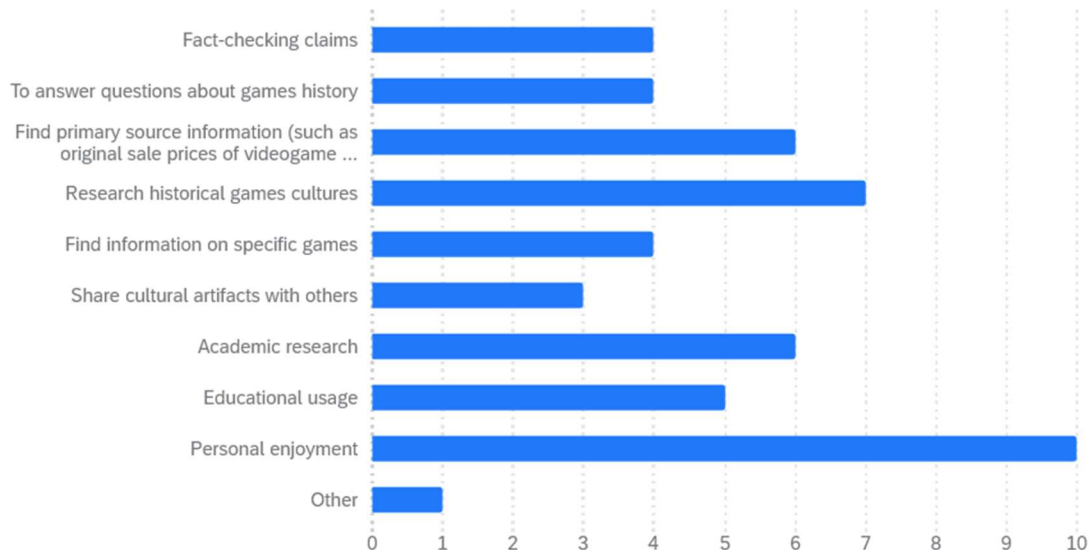
### INDIE HISTORIANS - [52 RESPONSES]



*Q: How do the materials hosted by the VGHF Digital Library benefit you and/or your work?  
(Indie Historians)*

For our group deepest in the trenches of the internet, the Indie Historians have deep usage of the library's resources up until a very specific point. The high response rates in similar areas to our other Historian group show that there is strong overlap between the ways professional and hobbyist historians use the library. This group is the best at sharing their research with others which can be leveraged to lead the way on showing other groups what to look for when curating for public exhibition (or just posting online in general). However, they employ very little academic research or educational usage which isn't unexpected, but it is worrying that they may not see roads for applying their work towards the education of others. Share yes, teach no. There is a great opportunity here to better bridge hobbyist games research towards scholarship by showing researchers how they can apply the research for their youtube videos to formal academic structures (even if they aren't specifically part of one). This chart shows precisely where we can empower burgeoning independent scholars – which will be really important as this is the group that will specifically be becoming experts on the materials in the digital library (with luck, hopefully even more expert than the Head Librarian!)

#### **EDUCATORS - [11 RESPONSES]**

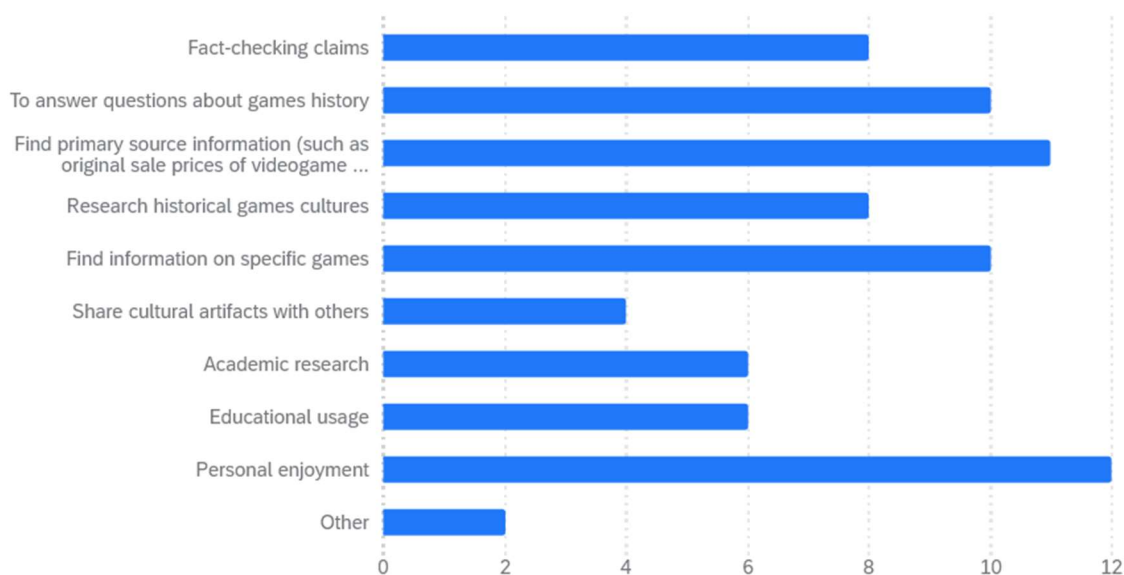


*Q: How do the materials hosted by the VGHF Digital Library benefit you and/or your work?  
(Educators)*

Educators have a smaller response pool than most groups, but they were also the most timid (or most precise) with their choices. They do some fact-checking, querying, sharing, and finding info on specific games, but those don't align with the scholar crew's main motivations as much as researching culture, finding primary source info, academic research, and other educational use. But for a group of scholars, that educational usage is still really low. Are people having general trouble with identifying a games library as a place for learning? I wonder if this is where we are seeing how games, even in a library, are still seen as less-serious toys if even our Educators group is struggling to apply the library

resources towards educational uses. Overall there is an opportunity here for better connecting with scholastic users and their uses of the digital library.

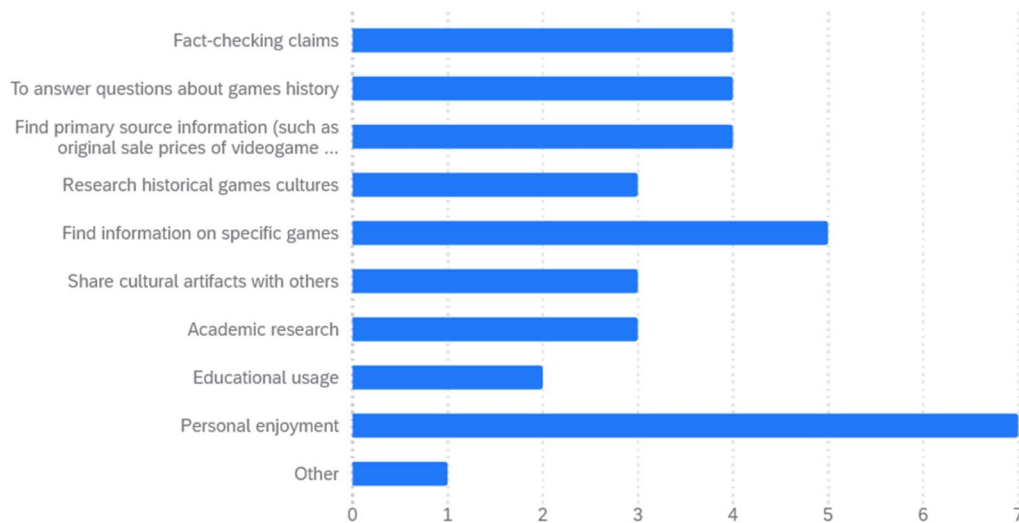
### **LAMS - [14 RESPONSES]**



*Q: How do the materials hosted by the VGHF Digital Library benefit you and/or your work? (LAMs)*

Our heritage allies have a similar set of uses compared to the historian groups but with a bit more educational usage and less sharing with others which implies to me that they are building up knowledge sources that can be prompted. Basically, they know things and are set up to be asked about it! But the overall volume and shape of this data is very hopeful for just how useful the heritage sector around games is finding the digital library! The next steps are to identify what projects are happening in this area and how to get the historians looped in on what projects are happening around here.

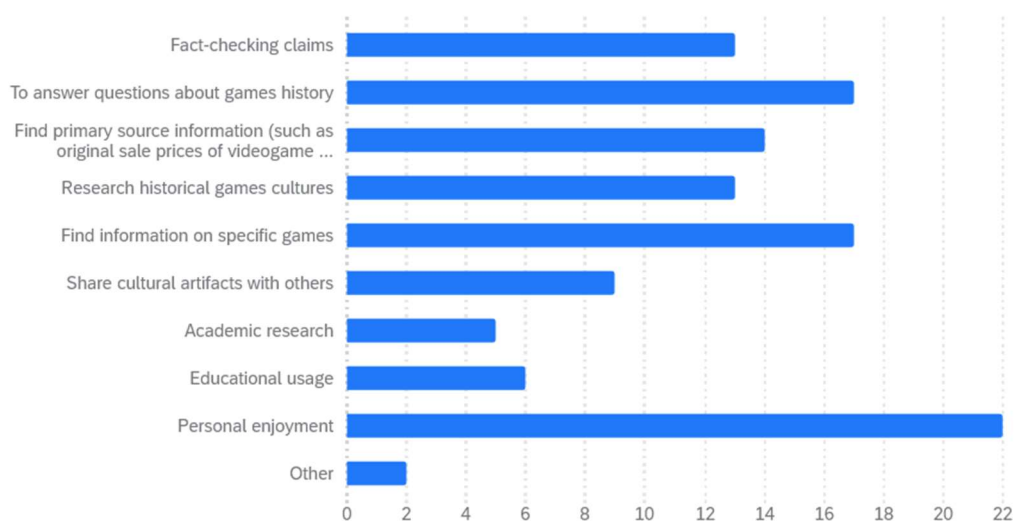
### PRO DEVS - [8 RESPONSES]



*Q: How do the materials hosted by the VGHF Digital Library benefit you and/or your work?  
(Pro Devs)*

Even though there are not many responses, analyzing this data gives me the distinct feeling Pro Devs are still searching for ways they want to use the library's resources. It's starting to take some shape similar to the others, but that may just be from how this group overlaps so heavily with the others. It leads to this immature shape without any real major drive. Now if there is one place I'd love to see an increase in educational usage, this is the one. That could be as simple as bringing devs into the library (digitally) to show others how they read these artifacts and what the materials can be used for.

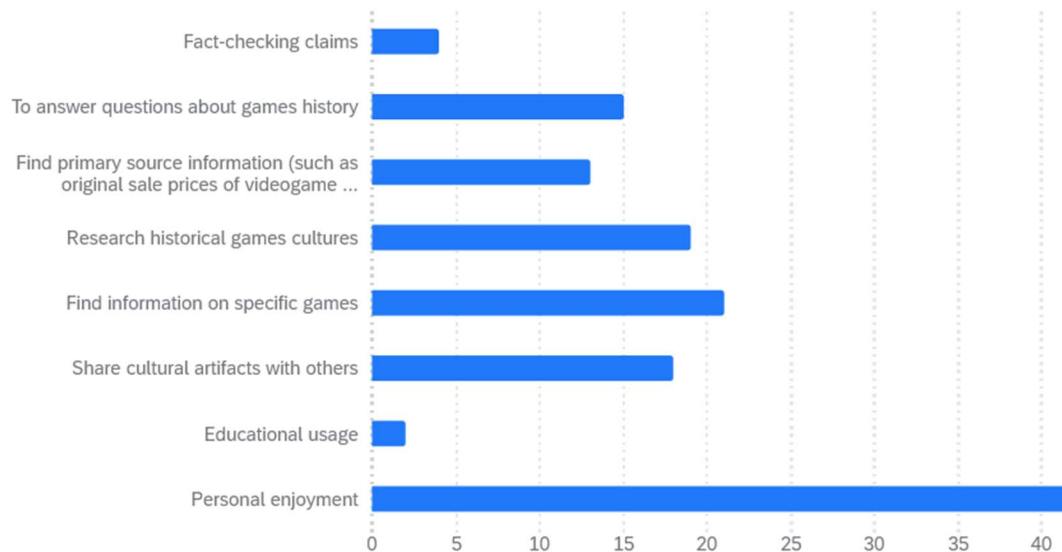
### INDIE DEVS - [23 RESPONSES]



*Q: How do the materials hosted by the VGHF Digital Library benefit you and/or your work?  
(Indie Devs)*

Why are indie developers going to the games history library? To understand specific games they are inspired by and to answer questions about games history. We can always be hammering this point home that developers can learn from the successes and failures of past game development through the library (we know a bit of history can do a lot to prevent crashing out about current times). Research and educational use is low, but it's a much bigger deal for the Indie Historians than the Devs who have enough on their plate for how they can apply research. We want Indie Devs to know it's healthy for them to hang out here, but that they don't have to do any extra work to reap great benefits from the library. Even still, with 39% of Indie Devs sharing artifacts with others, that is a good sign that they enjoy their time with the library even more than our other user groups.

### ENTHUSIASTS - [48 RESPONSES]

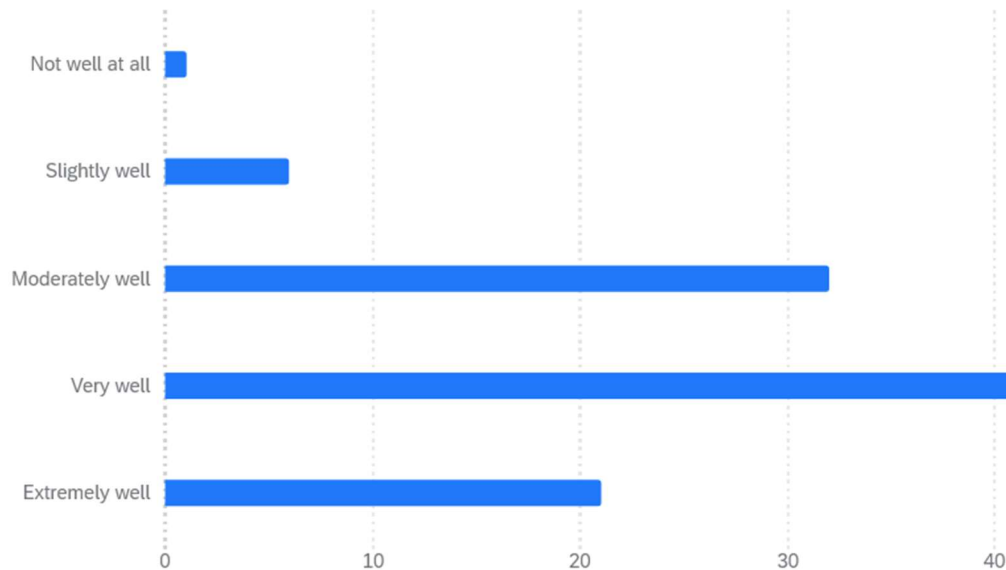


*Q: How do the materials hosted by the VGHF Digital Library benefit you and/or your work?  
(Enthusiasts)*

This feels like what normal people would think about library usage. It makes the other roles' more applied usage feel rich in comparison. One way of looking at this is that the Pure Collectors and Enthusiasts simply do not put as much use into the library as much as others. They are fans, but without identifying a role within themselves to apply usage, they end up with little drive to actually use the thing. I do believe their fandom can be leveraged towards general librarianship though, and that this data can help inspire stronger usage from the care and passion of collectors and enthusiasts. This can be highlighted as digital citizenship endeavors and the VGHF could lead a charge on the civic need for communities to be able to inform themselves of history. With more projects like the recent Earthbound video I bet we'll inspire even more enthusiasts to either increase these numbers or to take up a specific role that puts them in a community that already employs library strategies.

## 10: HOW IS THE USER EXPERIENCE?

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*Q: How did discoverability features in the Digital Library support your experience? When you used the Digital Library how well did our discoverability features address your needs?*

The VGHF takes a lot of pride in its document OCR and the ways it works to make the library extremely searchable on multiple axes, and so this question will make sure that no group is being left out with how this search-central system works. The current iteration of the Digital Library has limitations in its advanced search capabilities and I've been critical of its left bar while search results are displayed. This question was only given to users who have used the digital library from [Question 7]. If we give each answer above between 1 and 5 stars, with 1 being [Not Well At All] and 5 being [Extremely Well] then the average of each role breaks down as thus:

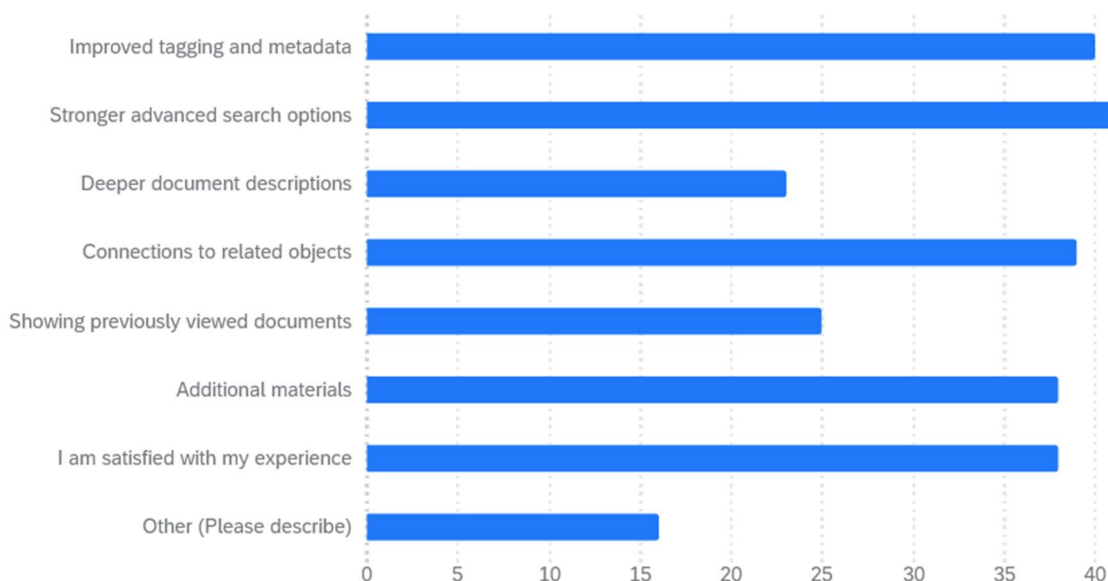
| Identity Group   | Discoverability Joy Average (# of responses) |
|------------------|----------------------------------------------|
| LAMs             | 3.2 Stars (11)                               |
| Pro Historians   | 3.3 Stars (9)                                |
| Educators        | 3.6 Stars (7)                                |
| Indie Devs       | 3.7 Stars (18)                               |
| Indie Historians | 3.7 Stars (49)                               |



|                          |                |
|--------------------------|----------------|
| Enthusiasts <sup>2</sup> | 4.0 Stars (40) |
| Pro Devs <sup>3</sup>    | 4.6 Stars (3)  |

## Q11: USER IMPROVEMENTS

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*Q: What would you improve to increase usability of the collection and better address users needs?*

This is such a fantastic response and is probably my favorite dataset of this entire survey because it is so actionable. While users may look like they've selected 'everything', that is not at all the case. Each user group thoughtfully addressed their own needs: Educators and Indie Devs want more connections to related objects, LAMs want stronger tagging and metadata, Indie Historians and Pro Devs want stronger advanced search options, Pro Historians are nearly tied up on everything including showing previously viewed documents, and Enthusiasts are generally satisfied. It's extremely impressive how it has all lined up to look tied, and most importantly we know they care with thought to the question because this has the most described [Other] options.

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<sup>2</sup> Just as the previous chart, Enthusiasts value can't be compared directly to the others in this chart as theirs is an exclusive group. But they sure are jolly!

<sup>3</sup> With only 3 responses in this category and since their responses overlap with other roles, Pro Devs can't be used as any sort of trend indicator that they are substantially happier than other roles. But if they are, then praise be to Frank that *something* can brighten up their tough lives.

I haven't mentioned our great [Other] responses yet because I think they will serve best as a closer to our analysis, but this is the area where people have made specific their uses: Lots of requests for download formats that may not be as actionable, but have consistent user concern:

“disc images in iso format instead of bin and cue files!”

“I wish it was possible to download PSDs without have to download the full .iso,  
I'm on Mac and the discs don't mount lol”

“old picture files format converted to lossless modern”

“Allow download of images (both the modern format and original psd etc).”

“I cannot access promo images directly from the web. I have to download the disc image and mount it to access the file at full resolution.”

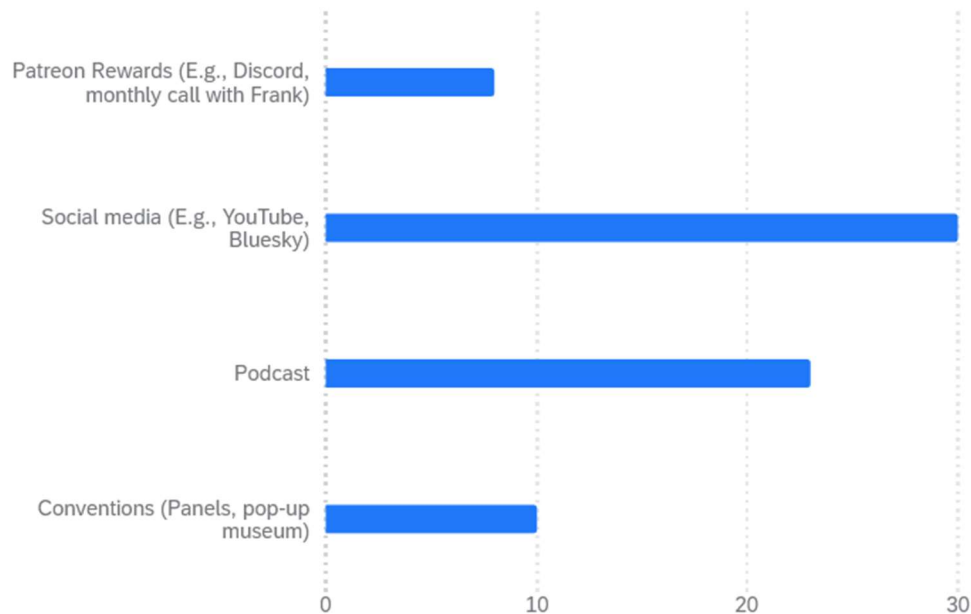
There are a few comments about wanting more materials, more prototypes, and one about not being able to find Nintendo Power when searching for it, but the most interesting was:

“When searching for prices it is often difficult. Saving spreads preference as a cookie would be helpful. Having hyperlinks to jump directly to the found text in a PDF would be helpful as well, having to open the PDF then ctrl + f wastes more time.”

There's three different needs packed into this comment: They'd like their spread preference saved (Go, Team Even Spreads!), they want a way to more easily associate their search result with the document (Two clicks and then a ctrl+F can lead to user context loss or distraction), and they'd like links to 'jump' around documents. The commenter doesn't even mind if cookies were used in the background to keep their user session more personalized, which I had not seen brought up in my research up to this point, even when I asked directly about it in my user interviews.

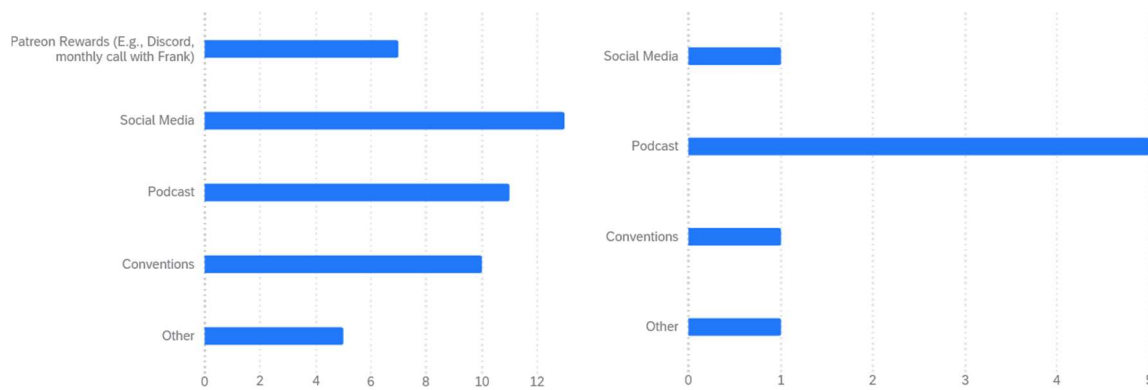
Overall, the results here are a great, clear set of desires that the VGHF can respond to with development projects over the year, and now we know that the users will respond warmly with a pretty thorough understanding of how they can use these improvements to better their research.

## SECTION FOUR: COMMUNITY ACTIVATIONS



*Q: Which parts of our community outreach have you interacted with?  
[34 Responses]*

The following three questions were only given to respondents who responded [Yes] to [Question 6] saying that they have donated to the VGHF, so this data comes from the donors directly. There is little surprise to the data here as the things that take the least amount of effort to participate are the majority, but not by much and each section is higher than I would have expected. Seeing 67% of donors say they have listened to the podcast is heartening. And with that we can do some simple associations like “60% of Donating Podcast-listeners use Bluesky and over 50% use Youtube”. We also asked what they would like to see more of, which led to a very similar shaped graph. When breaking down for roles there isn’t enough data inside this broken down bit to draw conclusions, but it’s interesting how much the Enthusiast Donors really want more Podcast content:



*Q: Are there parts of our community you would like to see more emphasized?*

*(LEFT- All Users)*

*(RIGHT- Just Enthusiasts)*

*[LEFT- 26 Responses]*

*[RIGHT- 7 Responses]*

We also had a long-response question in between these two asking “What content are you most excited about” alongside the [Other] options to both questions above, where folks filled out insight on how they specifically feel about content:

“I’d like to see more Academic and Independent Research content. I hope that this archive becomes a big portal and also sets standards, industry and legal-wise?” - from one of our two users who interacted with every part of the survey at every role.

“[I’m excited to see more] development archives such as design docs, prototypes, concept art, ideas, etc”

“I’d be interested in seeing the prototypes in the Mark Flitman collection be released. There’s a lot of Dragon Ball-related stuff in there.”

“I’ve really enjoyed the candid demonstrations where Frank has dumped old rom chips or talked about recovering basically trashed things from industry partners looking to offload an uncurated archive.”

“Source code/dev materials, probably?”

“All of it! I would love to work with VGHF in some capacity. Seeing the recent update about creating a new fundraiser position gives me hope that there may one day be a need for a data scientist.”

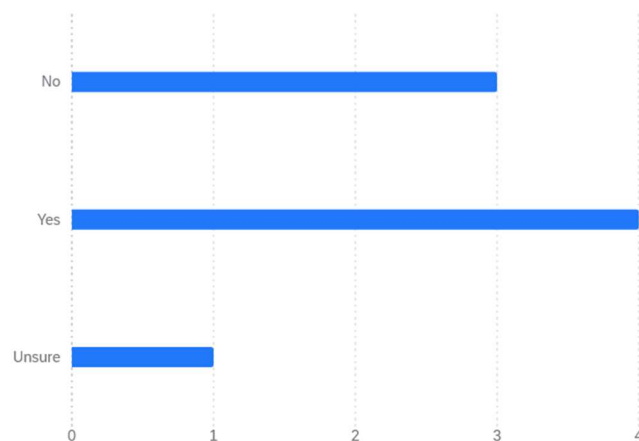
It’s a wide array of input, including more points where prototypes are especially notable (they seem to equate it to something that is otherwise completely lost being found, which does feel good to the soul regardless of whether or not the chips have any real historical value). There are also donors explicitly asking to help with projects involving the contents of the digital library, which is a great place to be. The Mark Flitman comment is the coolest comment just because of how in-the-know it is to the library and its purposes.

## SECTION FIVE: QUESTIONS FOR SPECIFIC USER IDENTITIES

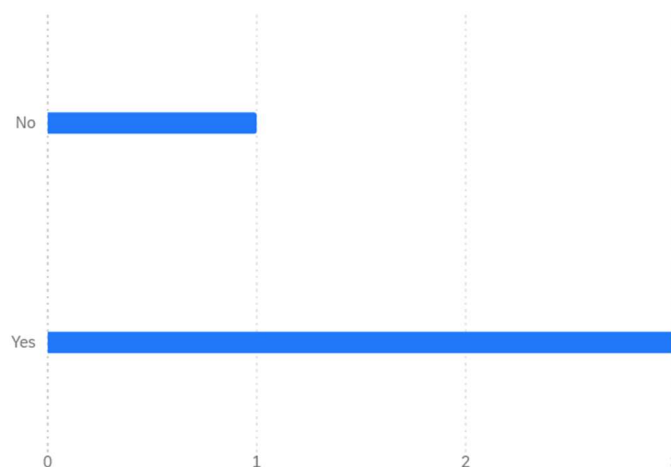
### QUESTIONS FOR PROFESSIONAL DEVS:

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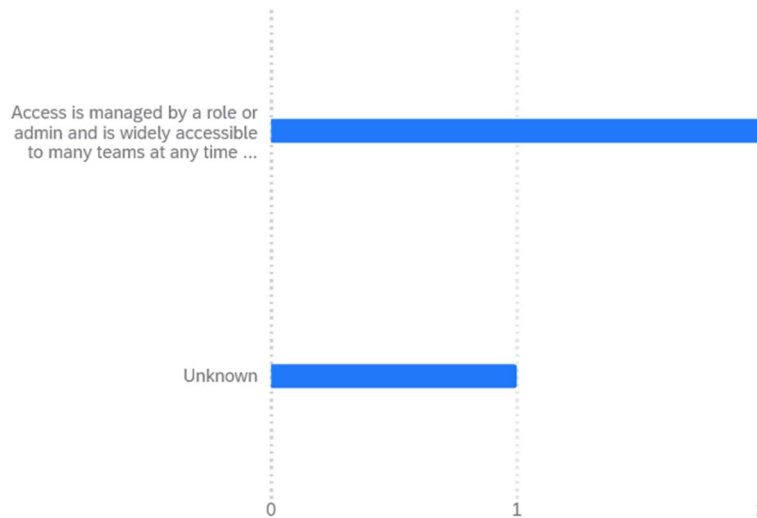
With the rare opportunity to ask about archival techniques to professional game developers from a respected institution, I asked five questions to explore how devs identify their organization's ability to archive their work. I wasn't expecting too many responses here because the professional game dev industry is much smaller than academia, historians, archivists, etc. They are also the group with the most tenuous use case for the digital library but they are the only group who sees work like theirs being directly archived by the VGHF, and may be hoping to be archived in the future (or present!). Their data is very valuable in context, which is why I made sure they were the first group in this section, just in case something popped up to be actionable. And with 8 respondents, we have just enough data to possibly start pursuing some deeper research!



*Q: Are there preservation policies for game related materials/artifacts at the company you work/worked for?*

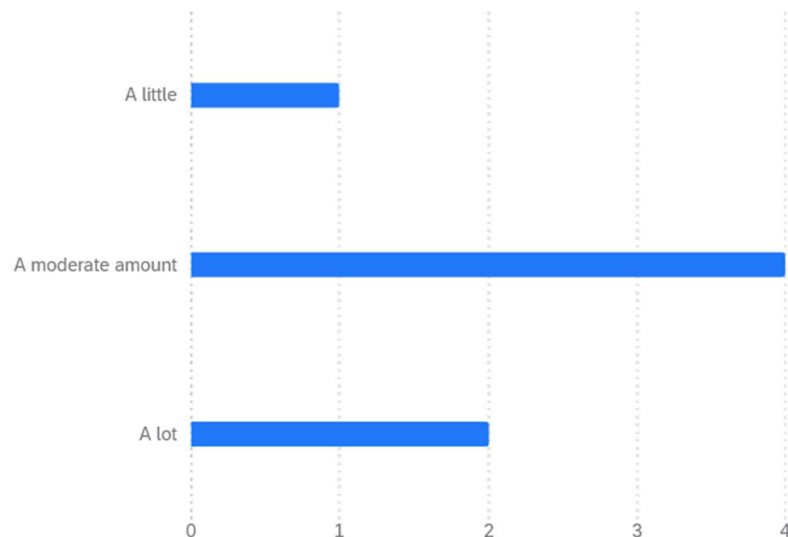


*Q: Is there a dedicated individual/team to perform this work?*



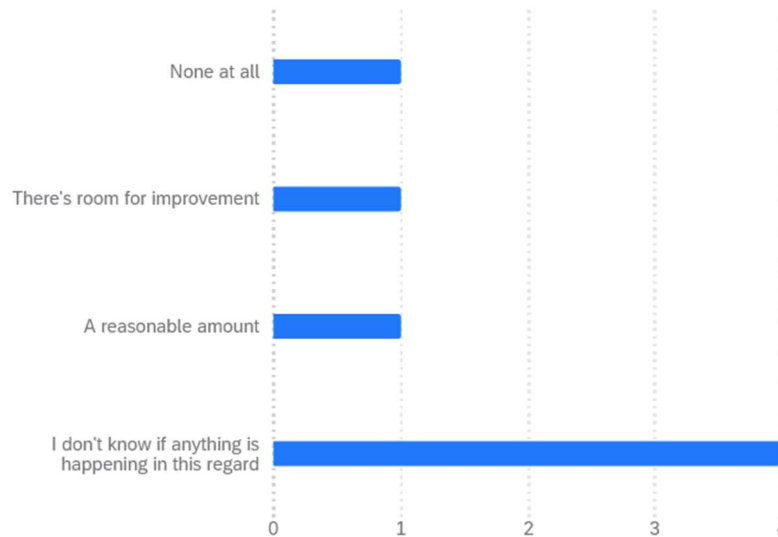
*Q: How are the materials in your archive or Content Management System (CMS) utilized?*

First, are there preservation policies at work? If so, is there a dedicated role for this work and who is allowed access? We have four hits! And of those four hits, three of them have a dedicated role, and two of them have employee-level access to that content management system! For me, this is groundbreaking to see that it could be even as high as 50% of industry developers know how the materials they develop are being stored. I want that number to be much higher as an industry standard, but I was worried we'd be working from a much lower number. This question had other options that represented less secure access, and I'm happy to see nobody stuck in the cold with restricted access to their own work. Most importantly, with two out of four industry workers being able to identify how to access their, or their peers', archived work, that's another 50% hope that companies have archival practices and policies. In a more focused survey for professional devs, this question could be a pathway to deep industry research. But do our users feel like their current level of access is adequate?



*Q: How concerned are you with preserving your game related work?*





*Q: In your opinion, how much effort is being put into preserving game-related materials at your company?*

This question specifically asked for the preservation of “game related work” as opposed to the game itself being preserved, and we can see that this is a concern to almost every employee polled, but they cannot tell if there is anything being done to preserve their work, which makes this a simmering problem. Not something they don’t care about, nor is it an existential emergency or anything, but an ounce of care from companies could go a long way in making the workplace a better place. When I see that even one person said things are ‘reasonable’ at their company and one that says ‘room for improvement’ that means this is not an impossible or unreasonable thing to ask employees about their place of work.

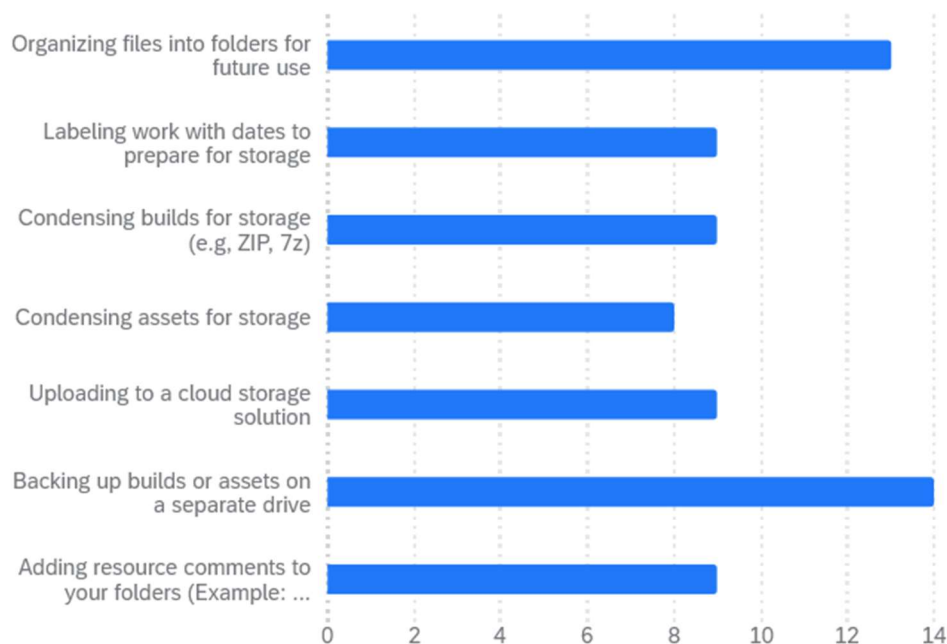
While there are not enough respondents to make any generalizations, this is just enough data to know that it is worth pursuing for further research. It could be incredibly fruitful for gaining industry allies, advocating for company policy, and making the games industry a little brighter with the knowledge that amongst all the layoffs, project cancellations, and expertise loss that the work itself may still be accessible and used in future projects. Industry devs in the VGHF’s orbit very plainly understand and appreciate the goals involved in archiving their work-in-progress and feel similarly protective of it. Also, this proves game developers at all levels are searching through and possibly taking inspiration from the VGHF digital library which is itself a huge success!

## QUESTIONS FOR INDIE DEVS:

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Welcome to my house! Indie game development is very dear to me as I have been deeply ingrained in this scene for about 15 years. Phil and Lane both asked about this set of questions in particular, because they were seen as having the least to do with the VGHF Digital Library, but I believed that these questions can bear fruit for games heritage,

especially since I believed that many library users would personally identify with this space. I prototyped these questions with other developers before their inclusion in the survey. Since they are technical questions, asked in ways that demand expertise, from respondents that may have never needed to think deeply about their own archivalship before, I wanted to make sure they were clearly worded in a way developers would understand. Thank you for letting me cook on this, and welcome to my advent of Indie Game Librarianship (with all credit to Laine Nooney for the inspiration):



*Q: Which of the following preservation-related operations or tasks have you done with your own work? - [18 Responses]*

I wanted Indie Developers to feel like the VGHF will take them seriously if they are taking their own archiving seriously (it's highly likely nobody will do the archiving work for you within this space - but if they do, they'll want a reliable disc, not a risky hard drive). But I also wanted respondents to feel like this is an accessible task. I didn't just ask if they put things into folders, I wanted respondents to understand that their folder hierarchies have preservation value. If a team or a solo-developer understands how ZIP works to condense their files, they are probably already doing it. But there is also a complication within this question's answers. Is it better to upload to the cloud or store on a drive? Or both (e.g., the 3-2-1 Rule)? I also added one complex archivalship option inspired by my data curation class, adding a README to your folders to describe the contents, and am happily surprised that more than half of the respondents use it. For us though, this data is very interesting in that more devs have backups on separate drives than they have comments or storage. Arguably, this is bad practice for indie devs, as separate drives will probably not last the decades needed for these kinds of archival projects. Only 65% of respondents who back up on a separate drive also upload to a cloud storage solution, whereas 100% of cloud storage users also use a separate drive. I will note that four surveys responded with every

single option and indie developers on average chose 3.5 of the possible archival tasks, which is why the bars look so similarly high.

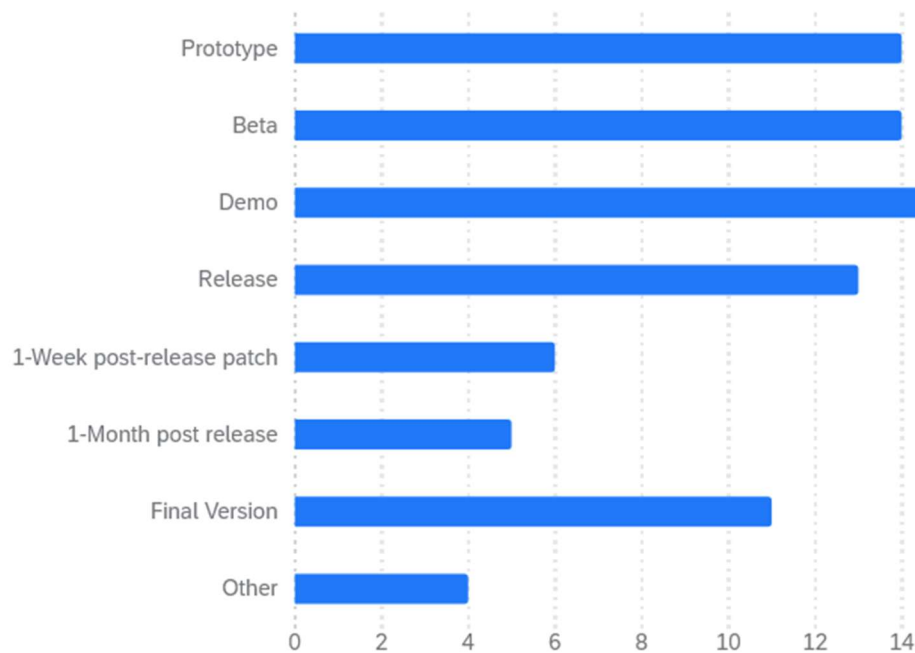
The next question asked for a list of the indie developers' most important file types for their work. This question is wholly inspired by the VGHF. I want to know what types of materials they will be developing and how stable those materials will be in the future. With 12 respondents, it is just enough to make some important generalizations, as well as to identify common values, outliers, and the general shape of our indie developer survey takers:

- .zs, .png, .psd, .blend, .wav, .mid
- .cs, .fbx, .psd, .md, .wav, .mp4
- .wav, .gltf, .png
- .wav, .png, .fbx, .docs, .pdf
- .zip, .gam, .dll, .exe
- .h, .cpp, .cs, .asset, .blend, .fbx
- .md, .gltf, .gd, .uproject, .wav, .png
- .png, .wav, .ogg, .bmp, .zip, .pdf
- .dmg, .iso, .eps, .psd, .ai, .dae
- .png, .psd, .txt, .doc, .gif, .avi
- .png, .wav, .mp3, .gif
- .csv, .xls (independent research)

58% of respondents identified .png and .wav with most identifying .png as the first or second-most immediately important. 83% of respondents added a finished art format with 50% using 3D image formats [.gltf, .fbx, .dae] and 58% responding with 2D image formats [.png, .gif, .bmp]. 42% offered proprietary art file-types that would be harder to inspect within an archive without all related files intact: [.psd, .ai, .dae, .blend, .asset]. Note the four users who specified multiple audio formats [.wav, .mid, .ogg, .mp3]. Having multiple or redundant audio formats could be important for indie game development. Five documentation lovers [.md, .docs, .doc, .pdf, .txt] and two realheads working with raw-ass video [.mp4, .avi]. Only two people mentioned code though [.cs, .h, .cpp] which makes me think we don't have as many coders in the responses as we do artists and all-rounders. Special shoutout to our weirdo hero who is the only person to suggest executable game file, save, and folder formats, I want to believe they are the mythical indie game producer unicorn (or a modder in the trenches).

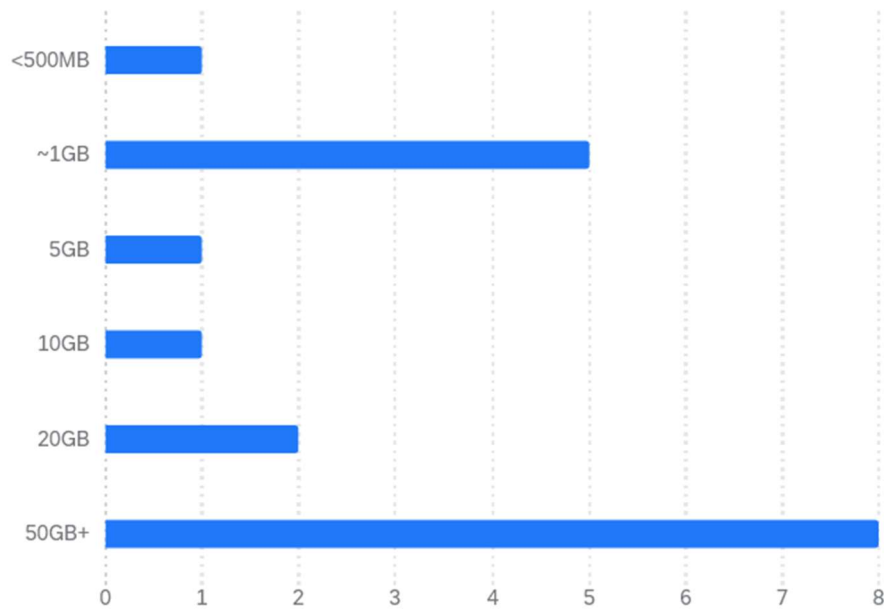
I did not make specific any type of indie-games 'work', so our independent researcher working with indie games can definitely hang out here. It makes any other patterns all the more potent, as our users could've chosen absolutely anything. All file types presented are known standards with over a decade of usage (other than .zs) so I do not foresee any issues

recommending that independent devs continue to self-archive when they can. I believe these lists contain mostly good sense and wise understanding of what goes into archiving work and that if the VGHF were to recommend methods of self-archiving that developers would be capable of following those recommendations without any trouble. There is a possible bias in this data that these digital library users may know better than the average developer on preservation techniques, but I don't think that should affect any forward motion on these types of projects.



*Q: (Optional) Please select the releases/build versions that you feel are important to preserve*  
*[17 Responses]*

Moving on to version preservation, this question shows initial data that the VGHF Library-using Indie Devs' hunger is not slaked until a game is officially released. Perhaps all pre-release data is seen as potential 'lost media', but I find that to be a bit too gluttonous of an approach to preservation. But I respect the perspective that devs specifically would have to want to preserve their [Demos] as those are materials they specifically employ to share a smaller portion of their game with an audience they are looking to impress - archive-using researchers could be that audience too - so it might be worth looking into if demos have any use to researchers, historians, or archivists. Our data unfortunately gets too small and doesn't change much if we only isolate our historians opinions, so we can't look further into this here. I am interested that indie developers don't see as much use out of anything after release as some games can change dramatically after release. Some have specifically written in to preserve "Everything" and "Every pre-released version" which has helped confirm my judgement that while indie devs understand the actions of preservation, they may not understand the goals and reasoning within acts of preservation.



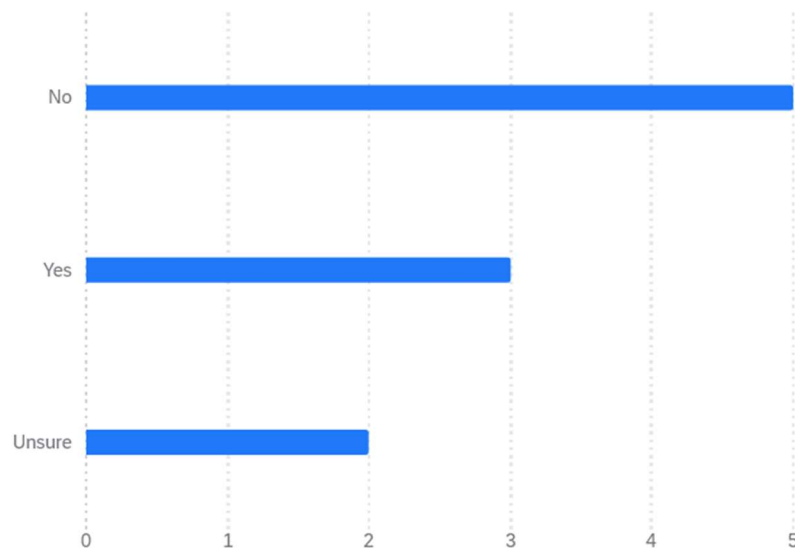
*Q: To the best of your knowledge, what would the minimum storage requirements be for archiving materials that are relevant to your work?*

And that leads us to the final question for the indie game developers, where I ask possibly the coldest closing question I can to catch indie developers outside of their wheelhouse. When the rubber finally meets the road, how much data do you believe it will cost to store your work in your own archive? Why does it stop at 50GB when we know games (even independently developed games) that are larger than that? This is where I get to smile like Alton Brown on Chopped, and reveal to all of our contestants that 50GB happens to be the reasonable maximum size for our mystery ingredient: Consumer-available Discs. It would currently be unreasonable to ask indie devs to set up disc burners for expensive triple-layer BDXL discs whereas blu-ray burners may be accessible via library or university resources. But the real question obviously being asked here is, can you get your archive to less than 50GB? Whether it is 1GB, 5GB, or 20GB obviously doesn't matter, because the *majority* of developers here have said "Yes, I can. That is no problem - even 20GB is workable if restricted." Perhaps after three straight questions asking users to idealize their archiving situation, I have set some users up to fall for this question in a way that may bias the data. I believe the minimum for archival purposes could be a single build of a few games, some documentation, and maybe a short video of the games being played, which could amount to about 20GB in a single indie game, but I do not believe 44% of indie devs require over 50GB to archive their work. To compare this data to our previous questions, our 50GB+ crew only contains half of the four respondents who typed "preserve everything" in the previous question. There is no strong correlation between which other identities this group of 8 responded with (types of expertise), how many they responded with (depth of expertise), nor is there a correlation with what types of files they would prefer to archive or what type of archiving they are already doing (such as if they are specifically a 3D artist for indie games and would be imagining that type of portfolio archive). This means it could genuinely be respondents reading the question too quickly rather than misunderstanding a primary goal of material preservation.

To close the door on my indie game exploration, I am confident that continuing to ask these types of questions around small-team and solo games spaces would be incredibly potent for starting to develop a set of best practices for independent game preservation (which I believe would trickle outwards to guiding limits on other forms of art/media self-preservation, as games labor practices often stem outwards to other fields due to technology development). Currently, that type of work is outside of the scope of the VGHF. However, our data shows that this is a primary user group who would follow guidance given by the VGHF, and so this might be one of the most appropriate places to host a kind of work that could easily impact the VGHF down the line. The most immediate place this could impact the VGHF within the scope of its current mission, would be if this type of work inspired the creation of an Indie Video Game Archive. That type of space could guide how this work is done without needing to wait for which indie games become considered to have historical or heritage value.

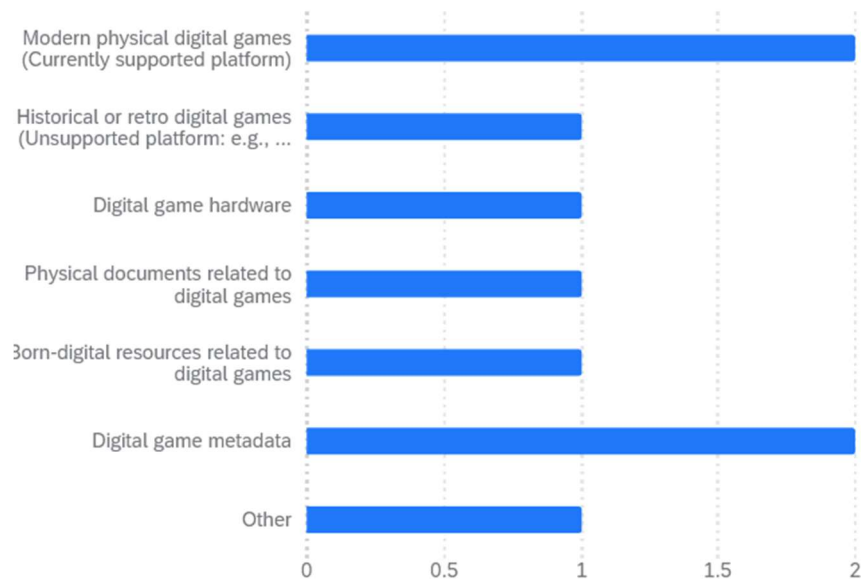
## QUESTIONS FOR CULTURAL HERITAGE INSTITUTIONS (LIBRARIES, ARCHIVES, MUSEUMS - LAMS)

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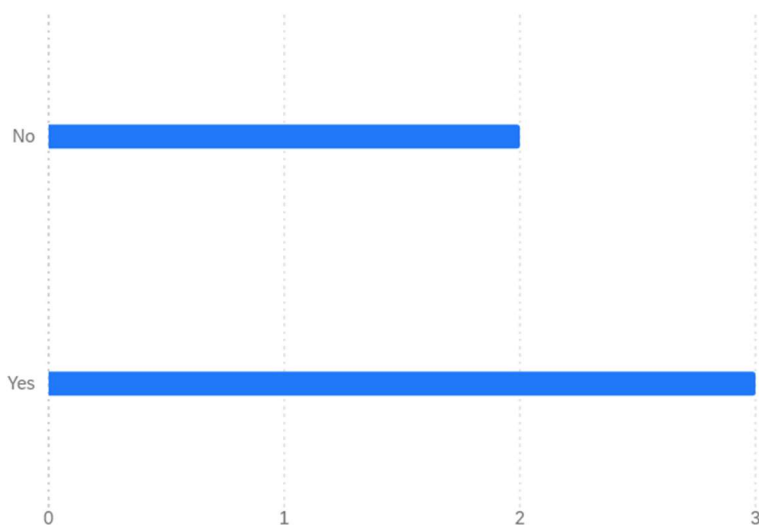


*Q: Does your institution currently collect digital games and/or game related materials?*

Our LAMs-specific usergroup questions have three questions, however the questions given after this first one are split off based on the [Yes] and [No/Unsure] camps so I could ask each group their library experience. So three respondents were given the following question and the other 5 were given the one after.



*Q: What types of materials are a part of your collection or collection development policy?*



*Q: Have there been requests for digital games and/or related materials at your institution?*

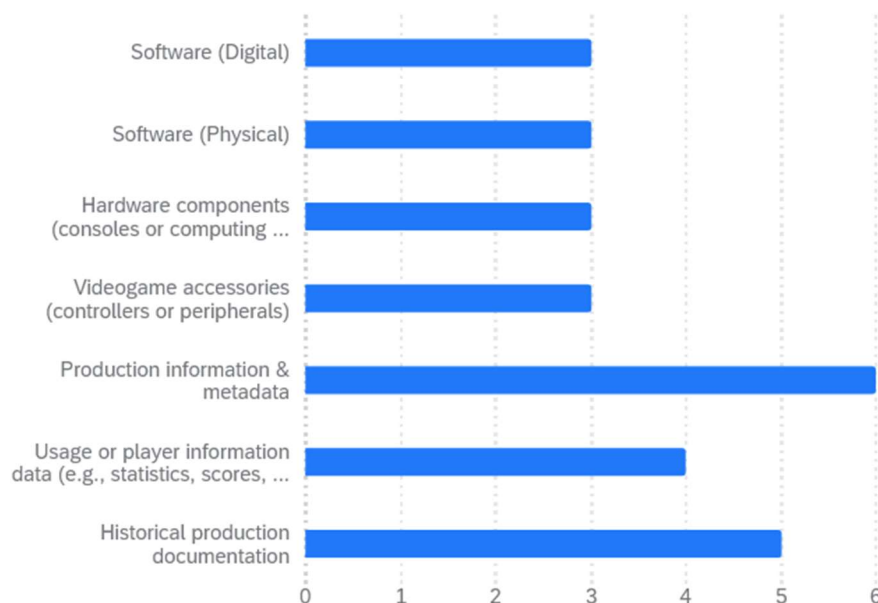
So what can we do with this under-researched area? We know from this that we only found 3-out-of-10 heritage workplaces that currently collect games and all three of them answered about what types of materials they use. One user selected every option (perhaps a museum like The Strong), the second only chose [Digital game metadata] (perhaps a game information repository or archive like MobyGames), and the third selected [Modern physical games] and wrote in “roms & source codes”. An incredibly diverse three individuals, making it really hard to pin down if we are on the right track here or not with the question itself. For all the users that don’t collect games, a majority of the respondents



have had a request for digital games<sup>4</sup>. This is consistent with how I understand games becoming a more ubiquitous consideration for LAMs the older the medium becomes, as well as how games increasingly intersect with other heritage sectors. With more data across this sector, such as from [the ongoing US Games-Based Library Services Survey](#), we can more accurately identify how much need there is in this area and the kinds of materials and services are in use at heritage institutions.

## QUESTIONS FOR EDUCATION GROUPS (TEACHERS/STUDENTS)

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*Q: What types of videogame materials are important for your work contributing to Games Education? - [8 Responses]*

Like the previous group, this group is also light on respondent count, however there is a wonderful depth to the two questions we asked them: What types of materials are important in your space, and what ways do you use videogames in your work? These are exploratory questions that thankfully supplied definitive endpoints in our data. No users needed to define their material usage further with [Other] and everyone chose a

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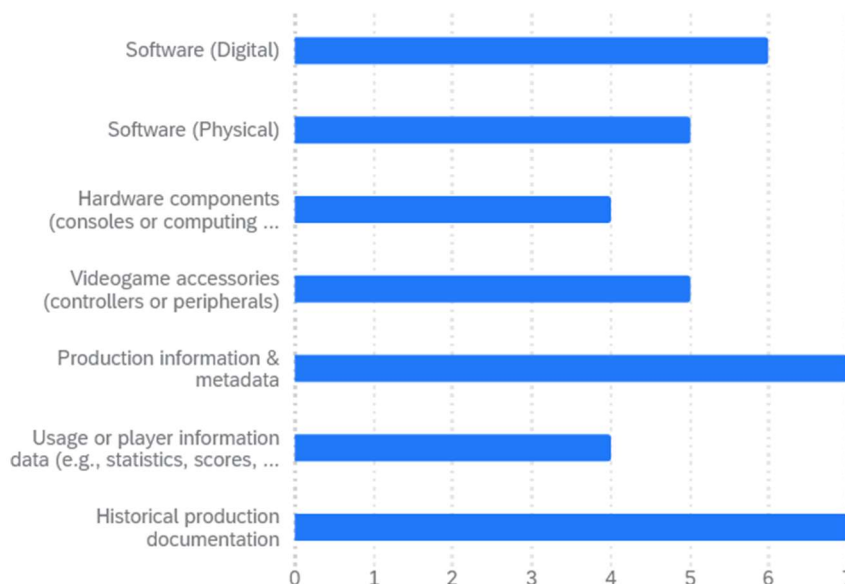
<sup>4</sup> The term ‘digital games’ was used here, as opposed to video games, so it can include library projects like The Table for digital board games. It also may include interactive modules at museums, depending on how they interpret the question. Not that the distinction is all that relevant with a pool this small.

smattering of all seven of our options which means all of these are useful to someone. We have a grad student who has used Production information, player information, and historical documentation. A soon-to-be educator whose partner is an educator who can describe uses for all seven groups within their work. A professor whose course is on “games as artifacts and communication” who directly uses all seven categories. And another user whose specialty is anything related to user experience that selected Accessories, Production information, and Player information. I believe this is the only question that directly asks about the output of players, and so I’m extremely heartened seeing 50% of respondents can get direct use out of it. Those are generally outside of the VGHFs scope, but only for difficulty of finding the right angle of collection, not for any policy restrictions. [Production Information] is not surprising to see as the topmost contributor since that is Wikipedia, basically. And [Historical production documentation] has a natural bias in this survey due to the survey being focused on the library that hosts that material.

And most importantly, they were all really really nice!

## QUESTIONS FOR PROFESSIONAL HISTORIANS

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*Q: What types of videogame materials are important for your work contributing to games research?*  
*[9 Responses]*

The historians associated with an institution of some kind received the same exploratory questions that the Educators group did. However, this group use videogame materials much more liberally than educators, especially the software itself: There were an average of 3.4 choices per Educator user vs 4.2 choices on average per Pro Historian. I’m glad to see they still have some use for [Player information] and it makes sense that they also predominantly use [Production info] and [Historical documentation]. Again, there are not

any edge case materials that we seem to be missing from this discussion which is a great sign we're on the right track.

As for their full answers to what type of work these groups do, there were half as many given answers compared to the Educators group and one of them is a repeat from the Educators one, so I'll print all of them below:

“[Repeat] Anything related to game genres, reviews (journalistics or user), user experience as a whole, assessing game experience during production, playtest...  
And things regarding communities or audiences, specifically : women, girls, marginalized population, accessibility / handicap , inclusivity, LGBTQI+ + physical ergonomomy as well”

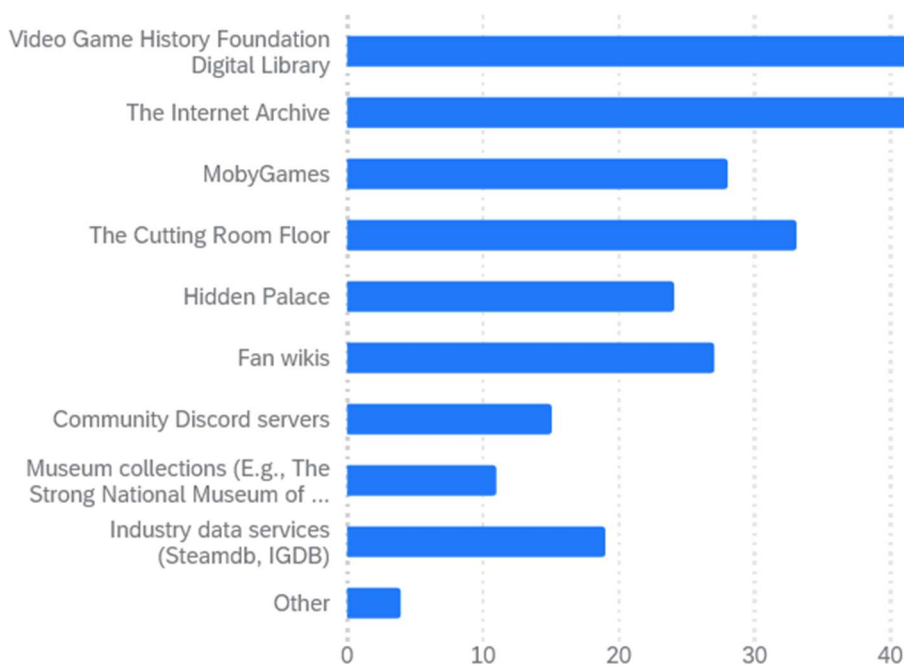
“For fanzines, guidebooks and general reference material alongside other groups like the Game Preservation Society and many more”

“I am working on a paper chronicling the development history of a specific peripheral. I've used the library as a starting point for some leads, which led me down a very intense rabbit hole.”

These responses more directly relate to the core categories of materials contained within the digital library, but they similarly run a wide gamut of focuses which combined with the education responses leads me to believe that the digital library is very strong for reaching many different schools of research and isn't just used by the humanities, the sciences, or art but many more types of historians across multiple fields.

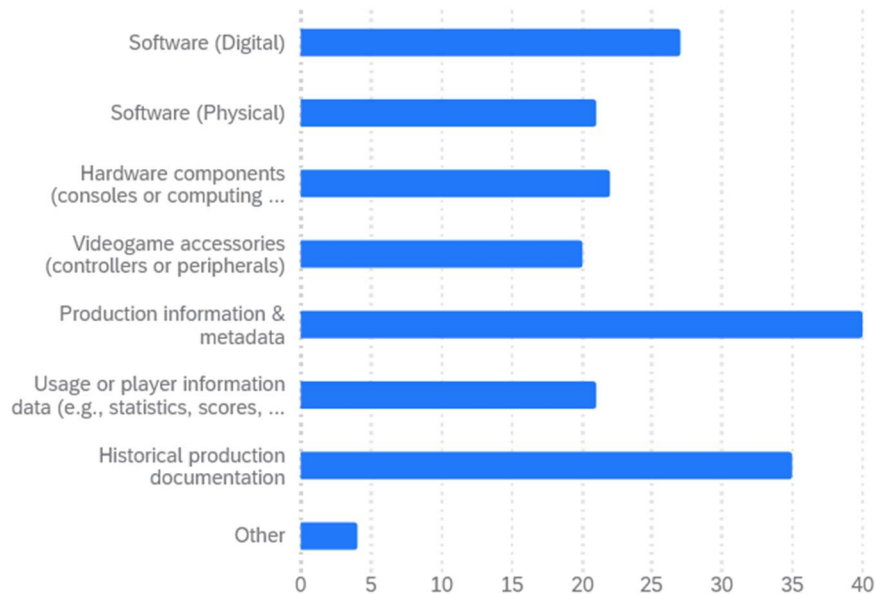
## QUESTIONS FOR INDIE HISTORIANS

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*Q: Which of the following online databases or archives do you use for your research? [46 Responses]*

I saved our largest and most exciting group for last with the same aboutness questions as the previous two groups, but also adding the above question about which online databases that the less affiliated group uses. We should have ample crossover with the previous two groups as well as 63% of users who chose Education or Pro Historian also chose Indie Historian. That is 100% of users claim to use [the digital library] AND [The Internet Archive]. Nobody directly suggested Wikipedia as an [Other] (but one person did suggest “Japanese Wikipedia, Gaming Alexandria”) but had I put Wikipedia on the list, I’d presume that is 100% as well. So we know we have a savvy group, but I’m especially impressed seeing that 100% of our LAMs, and both Dev groups that overlap with Indie Historians identified [The Cutting Room Floor] as a database they frequent. So I may have underestimated just how much any perceived ‘cut content’ is to these groups. 33% of users are starting to get into discord servers as a research point. I’m impressed that 24% of users surveyed have accessed museum collections too, as that is a much higher barrier of entry than public websites. This is another example of the level of expertise we polled with this service. It’s also great for reporting back to other libraries and museums how useful our services are together.



*Q: What types of videogame materials are important for your work contributing to (Indie) games research?*

This graph looks perfectly in between the previous two times this question was asked. The material needs of Indie Historians have a little less need for software than Indie Devs but more than Educators. The only difference is that this is the first time folks have mentioned any [Other] options where users specified “Interviews” for their special interest and “Merchandise” for their work in fandoms as materials they use for research work.

For our final question with this group, since almost half of the respondents (21) described how they used video game materials within their research, I have isolated their behaviors described and attributed them to four information seeking strategies

| Strategy | User Behaviors                                                                                                                                                     |
|----------|--------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Browse   | Magazine reading, rabbit holes, tangents, or preparation for future projects                                                                                       |
| Search   | Monster Hunter, Giorgio de Chirico, Fanzines, Guidebooks, Production art, Video game tie-ins to Warhammer, Games whose popularity was tied to hype but didn't last |
| Use      | Research for video creation, Historical Context, Understanding “The Developer’s Mindset”, Staff changes over time, Trend analysis, International analysis          |
| Request  | Comparing releases between regions, pre-release information                                                                                                        |

The Indie Historians were extremely clear about how they use the Digital Archive, and within this section users deeply expressed what they care so much about when they use the archive:

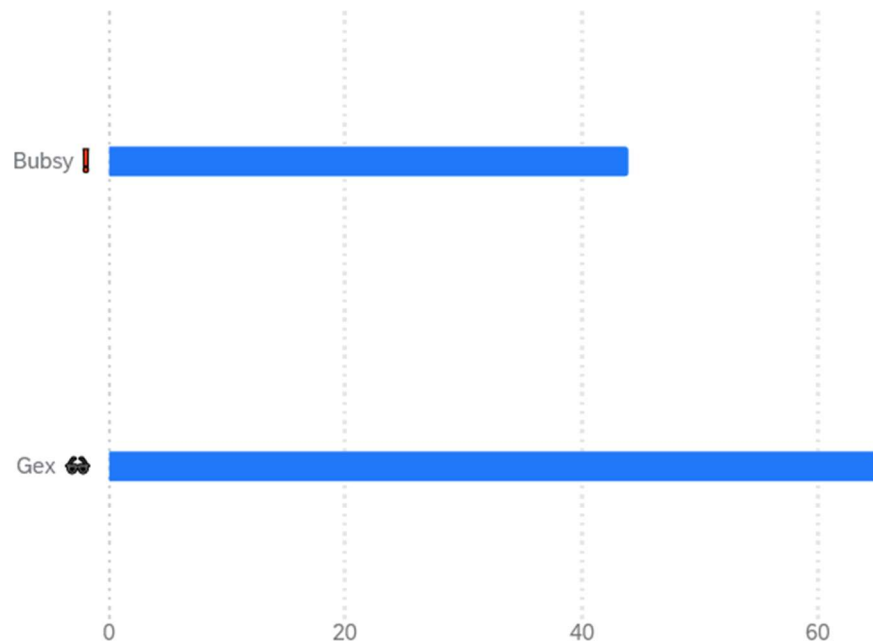
“I'm an amateur historian who has worked in the library field for more than a decade, but only recently realized that I could probably use those skills within the field of video games, as well. I'm currently using EndNote to try to compile all available interviews with FromSoftware president Hidetaka Miyazaki and the VGHF materials have been very helpful in pointing me towards sources I might not have otherwise used. Also: the collection of various press kits are excellent as someone who collects rare or uncommon items (slowly). Thanks for a fantastic archive.”

“I use the materials to try and construct an accurate historical record (eg. the still not entirely clear split of Interplay and Steve Jackson Games back in 1997), and preserve the sources - the Digital Rot is pervasive and it's very easy to lose track of history and thus what actually happened. This is also important from my perspective to provide resources and information for future developers and players, in the moment that we are living in - something that has, in centuries past, led to losing a lot of vital context, forcing us to rely on assumptions in certain areas of studying the past.”

“I often use the Digital Archive to seek out press materials that mention a game of interest prior to its release date. This information is sometimes critical for piecing together prerelease build information (especially via screenshots). And by searching for info after the game's release date, I can also find more details regarding the cultural impact of the game in the aftermath of its release. VGHF's excellent documentation of the text in each PDF makes searching for and copying down these sporadic excerpts extremely easy. It has saved me a lot of time.”

## SECTION SIX: BUBSY VS GEX

Drumroll please...



*Q: And finally, our community is dying to know: Bubsy or Gex?*  
*[109 Responses]*

This question was tied 50%/50% for the entire time the survey was taken until the final three days when *Bubsy 4D* released and Gex pulled wildly ahead. It's hard to tell if it was because the Bubsy fans were distracted or if everyone was sick of the bobcat's antics by then and were hungry for some tail time. Since Gex and Bubsy are both equally notable for their inaccessibility and lack of prestige, they are hipster classic- if a successful game were to come out for either mascot, they would momentarily lose that hipster shine which I believe was a behavior exhibited by how this poll dramatically shifted within its final week. (Congrats Fabraz, on a game that Bubsy truly deserved! Here's to Gex someday getting the love too!)

This question caused some survey respondents to try to take the survey again, but those became easy to distinguish since they came from the same place and usually had strange looking data values such as missing everything but the final question. I'd say asking this question, maybe because it was silly, was invaluable for helping guide the data cleaning process. It was also invaluable for identifying who made it to the end because while some respondents got bored of answering questions in the middle, everyone tuned in for the finale, resulting in a lot more finished surveys than there would have been otherwise.



## CONCLUSION

This survey was designed to spread out the VGHF's perceived user groups and find ways to get those groups to talk to one another. I'm completely satisfied with how wholly it identified those groups. It was also designed with longevity in mind, as the questions asked can be given new light when asked again later. There is plenty of room to expand on the types of data that this survey collects too- I really thought we were asking too many questions, but with how quickly users took the survey it seems we could've gone five, maybe even ten questions deeper! To conclude this report, I will write broadly about the VGHF based both on these results as well as this last year of researching the organization based on your goals as the VGHF enters the new Digital Library era.

## WHAT CAN OUR USER GROUPS DO TO BUILD THE DIGITAL ARCHIVE FOR EACH OTHER?

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This survey has produced data for six user groups based on work associated with the Digital Library. They each have shown unique needs and usages. **Indie Historians** come in with a thesis in mind and are looking for supporting or refuting evidence but will not as often cross-examine or put sources into dialogue. They do a lot to share sources they find, but not so much as applied research.

**Pro Historians** leverage professional inquiry to explore a wide range of topics but have less of a road towards sharing what that work is. They also have more technical needs and less bandwidth for solving them, so any way with which to stay available to this group specifically would be very fruitful for developing the infrastructure of the collection and the library.

This leads to the **Educators** crew who are exploring applied research and project development that the Indie Historians would be very interested in. They also would be the group who could disseminate systemic tricks for library usage for the Pro Librarians. The scholars are also looking for more reasons to design collective engagement projects with a videogame library and so they could be a direct group to engage with that can spread impact towards a lot of the other groups.

The **LAMs** are interesting because they are using the Digital Library at the broadest level and all of their uses could encompass the other user groups. LAMs users biggest need is to be 'pointed to' as reference and in-turn to be able to 'point at' the Digital Library. Institution-to-Institution Communication - like it's their hero-specific ultimate ability. Similar to Educators, they have a mutually beneficial reason to build projects for and with the VGHF. But LAMs will not be as deeply applied in their approach as the Educators group. LAM projects will build wide in a way that might entice more users to join

(Enthusiasts), whereas Educators projects are empowered towards building deep in a way that would be interesting to more applied users (Historians).

**Indie Devs** provided way more data than I would have thought before the study which revealed how much they love finding the games that inspire them within the list. However, their lack of library experience means they don't necessarily go deeper than their favorites. With guidance they could use their insight to guide a unique user experience compared to Historians that will in-turn bring more devs towards the library as they discover more unique uses for the library and the materials.

**Pro Devs** are not a populous group for the VGHF and our data is not enough to say much about their needs, but they have a unique perspective as possible donors (and most likely to source other major donors). Pro Devs may deservedly require a more direct sell towards ways they and their peers can use the library (and not just be 'in' it). This is where their 100% alignment with Indie Devs (remember that annoying coinkydink?) is actually helpful - we know by the data that equally as much as Indie Devs would love a library project that could make them a better developer, Pro Devs do too. Library projects in this direction would be a holistic industry benefit that can reciprocate into material donors.

The **Enthusiasts** group uses the digital library the least and it was difficult to see how this group applies itself. Enthusiasts also have a lot of needs but do not provide the resources nor expertise to be able to define what those needs are or how they are applicable to our library scope. They also don't share much material out, so it's difficult to see how building projects to meet their group's needs will help, unless the projects focused towards inspiring the Enthusiasts and Collectors (as almost all respondents are, to a degree) to become historians, developers, or educators. I think group projects would be perfect for Enthusiasts, as those can scale larger towards developer or historian expertise. Their diverse perspective and excitement could help bridge the gaps between perceived 'insiders' and 'outsiders' too, which is a perspective that they seem especially sensitive to compared to the other groups.

I'm thinking about how to develop library projects here because there was so much user feedback that said, "I want to help!" - which Phil sighed wistfully at hearing, as he has so little time for sudden project management. With guidance, all of these roles could cover each other's weaknesses and support each other in novel ways that expend little internal effort and end up growing the library in novel ways. I've listed an example below of a project concept that does not require VGHF supervision to run:

*An Example VGHF Digital Library Project For All Those Cool Folks Who 'Want To Help':*

Design a tutorial teaching users how to cross-reference a separate game information database (E.g., TCRF, MobyGames, [Archive.org](https://www.archive.org)) with the VGHF Digital Library. Your tutorial must lead users to applying both [magazines] and [game development materials] as cross-referential. These tutorials can have activities and mini-games within that can engage or inspire educational programs. [Mini-Khan Academy but for videogames and the Digital Archive] (Ex: Solon presents a tutorial workshop showing how to use the Otome Game Database with the VGHF! Terms to search for, leads to develop, previous historical terms around Otome and visual novels, etc.)

I believe setting up a project like this in a hackathon, game jam, or research jam type of format will engage a wide variety of users in fun ways, and they'll help find new ways to link to the VGHF. But most importantly, a project like this is easily managed outside the VGHF itself in a way that regards the various user groups we found in this survey.

## ONBOARDING NEW USERS AND 'THE ENGINE'

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It was so surprising to see that many of the digital library's newest users were coming from Google or from the wild internet rather than a social media space where the VGHF has a presence. But the data also proved that The Engine, as it currently is, works best for maintaining relationships with all levels of users. Previously, I've defined "The Engine" as the current combination of community capture events: Videos, Magazine Subs, Patreon, Donation Events, and the Podcast. We might be able to now add Shorts to that too. All of these substantially reach users whether they have just found the VGHF or if they have known about the org for years. The harder part though is discoverability as this engine can only help the organization continue to grow as more people continue to find services - but since we have data that people are finding Usage of the Digital Library organically with Google then we're in an incredibly good spot to not have to worry as much about that. We obviously knew the library was findable on Google but we didn't know that library users may only know of the VGHF via Google and that it could be a potent onboarding vector itself. It could be a part of The Engine itself - much in the same way Serebii.net is a database whose landing pages lead to plenty of community opportunities across the site (our survey itself proving that the banner is a valuable tool). As a last recommendation, if you're doing YT shorts, cross-post them to TikTok as there is both a sizable Gen-Z group on there and a #librariansOfTikTok community who would get a lot of mileage out of being introduced to the VGHF digital library through tiktok. They also often have fun trendy video ideas that keep up with the posting zeitgeist.

## RESULTS OF THE ATTRACTION TO PROTOTYPES

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Throughout the data from our survey, prototypes were a distinct distraction. A group of surveyed respondents strongly associate the VGHF and the Digital Library with prototype chips because they have seen Frank work with them and seen how those are a part of donated materials. I am not convinced that this kind of material is as historically actionable as the other materials in the digital archive, or if they can even be uploaded or worked with on the archive. But they have a lot of value in the collector community due to being a unique non-commercial artifact. Some may see that value as pertaining to historical value and make a moral imperative around how these must be preserved in a library. The fervor around prototypes builds up a grey market that the VGHF could have leverage over. Parts of this survey were designed to help define the policy around prototypes - so these responses were important for seeing how unclear this portion of the VGHF's collection is to users and how it shows up in the digital archive.

None of this is to say that it's wrong to work with prototypes or show them off, quite the contrary actually because it's as Indiana Jones as this job can get right now. But with that hype comes a lot of expectations, and it seems those expectations push games archivists towards the issues of librarian awe where they then have to diminish and isolate the hype - or- isolate themselves from the hype. "There are only two of us, we can't do everything" has been a strong refrain for publicly managing hype up to this point, but the VGHF is getting close to outgrowing that sentiment. It will start to ring hollow to outsiders as the library and preservation community start getting more established and more resources start coming in. It won't ever be false- this is libraries, there is always too much to do. But it makes it all the more important to manage that reputation as library work is much slower than what our prototype connoisseurs would want. So, if the VGHF keeps playing with cool green chips and showing off their contents at conventions and the like, then there's wisdom in pointing folks towards the policy that says software isn't in the Digital Library (and probably won't be hosted by the VGHF for some time- check Gaming Alexandria). And I'm hoping the development collection policy can be a more structural place to point folks who want to know the scope of current projects rather than admitting defeat by saying "we just don't have the time, there's only three of us here". The main reward of this is incoming donors not feeling like they are burdening the org with a request to donate.

#### TOP-CLASS WRITE-IN COMMENTS

*"I love everything the foundation does, but I am partial to the video documentaries. Phil's work on the Sega Channel video, and Frank's video on the NES launch were fantastic and full of info and stuff I have never seen before. I am excited to see what they do next!"*

*"I can't wait to see more materials in the library over time!"*

*"VGHF continually surprises me with not only the quality of preservation and collected materials, but the types of materials that get coverage on youtube and social media. I'm mostly excited for the surprise, because you never know what game or creator is going to show up! I'm also a big fan of the disc dumps with high-res promotional renders and advertising materials. I think that stuff is super interesting, and it's nice to have a definitive repository for these materials since we've only had poor quality scans, or photographs of some of these things for the longest time. I love what the VGHF does and I hope you exceed all your fundraising goals for years to come <3"*

*"I think the current balance [of community engagement] is pretty good. I see posts on socials all the time and love the youtube content especially. Keep up the fantastic work"*

*"This is Ty Schalter from the FunFactor podcast! As Frank and Phil know, we're a regular podcast dedicated to classic video game magazines (and viewing games*

*culture, then and now, through the lens of old games media). We use VGHF not just to view magazines themselves, but also information related to their publication, and/or the games, consoles, and companies those magazines cover/review/preview.”*

*“I’ve only just started doing anything archival related, but I’m really interested in the pre-release to first year of Monster Hunter Stories, which had some pretty interesting in-person events and dlc distributions (for instance, over 40 subquests were distributed by Monster Hunter Spirits 2 arcade machines, rotating on a daily basis. I have found 1 single mention of them in a Famitsu article and have yet to figure out the actual details of each subquest, though they seemed to all be for monsters that would otherwise be difficult for players to find in the postgame.)”*